

TABLE OF CONTENTS

AGENDA	2
NSS BOARD OF MANAGEMENT & STAFF 2007-2008	3
MINUTES OF 2007 ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING	4
ATTENDANCE LIST OF 2007 ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING	8
OVERVIEW OF NSS 2008	9
SERVICE REGIONS & OFFICE LOCATIONS	10
CHAIRMAN'S REPORT	11
DIRECTOR'S REPORT	12
SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM - <i>Introduction</i>	14
IMMIGRATION ADVICE & ASSISTANCE SCHEME (IAAAS)	15
CITIZENSHIP SUPPORT GRANTS PROGRAM	17
RURAL TEAM - <i>Introduction</i>	19
RURAL SUPPORT SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM	20
HUNTER WELFARE OUTREACH SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM	22
NEW ENGLAND SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM (ARMIDALE)	24
NEW ENGLAND SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM (TAMWORTH)	26
LINKS TO LEARNING COMMUNITY GRANTS PROGRAM	28
AGED CARE TEAM - <i>Introduction</i>	30
COMMUNITY AGED CARE PACKAGES	31
HUNTER MULTICULTURAL RESPITE SERVICE	33
COMMUNITY VISITORS SCHEME	35
MULTICULTURAL SOCIAL SUPPORT SERVICE (CENTRAL COAST)	37
AFRICAN TEAM - <i>Introduction</i>	39
COMMUNITY PROJECTS OFFICER	40
SUDANESE & AFRICAN COMMUNITIES SUPPORT PROJECT (SGP)	42
AFRICAN YOUTH PROJECT	44
AFRICAN FAMILY SUPPORT PROJECT (FAMILIES FIRST)	46
VOLUNTEERS CO-ORDINATOR	49
WELFARE TEAM - <i>Introduction</i>	51
FILIPINO WELFARE PROJECT	52
RUSSIAN WELFARE PROJECT	54
THAI WELFARE PROJECT	56
PACIFIC ISLANDER WELFARE PROJECT	58
MIGRANT & REFUGEE WOMEN'S SUPPORT PROJECT (SGP)	60
MULTICULTURAL FAMILY SUPPORT PROJECT (FAMILIES FIRST)	62
ADMINISTRATION & ADDITIONAL STAFF	64
CENTRE USAGE 2007-2008	65
2008 AT NSS - PHOTOGRAPHS & ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS	66
FINANCIAL REPORT 2007-2008	70
- CUTCHER & NEALE CHARTERED ACCOUNTANTS (1-27)	
- EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF AUDIT (1-6)	

NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN OF THE
24th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
OF
NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

TO BE HELD ON THURSDAY 27 NOVEMBER 2008
AT 8 CHAUCER STREET HAMILTON
AT 11.00am

1. OPENING & WELCOME
BY CHAIRMAN, MR HENRY CHAN
2. APOLOGIES
3. MINUTES OF 2007 AGM
4. BUSINESS ARISING
5. PRESENTATION OF REPORTS
6. CONFIRMATION OF AUDITORS
7. ELECTION -NSS MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE
8. GENERAL BUSINESS
9. CLOSE & LIGHT REFRESHMENTS

NSS BOARD OF MANAGEMENT

Chairperson	Mr Henry Chan
Vice Chairperson	Mr William Simanowsky
Treasurer	Mr John McLennan
Assistant Treasurer	Ms Trudy Mills-Evers
Secretary	Ms Alina Kizeweter
Assistant Secretary	Ms Sania Young
Director	Fthr Nicholas Zervas OAM
Director	Mr Ivan Klopčic OAM
Director	Mr Zoran Vasiljevic
Director	Mr Biko Syongoh

NSS STAFF

Director	Ms Violetta Walsh OAM
Assistant Director/Migration Agent/	
Special Projects Team Leader	Ms Lulu Tantos
Migration Agent	Ms Irina Lupish
Specialist Caseworker/OH&S Consultant	Ms Helen Buchanan
Citizenship Support Facilitator	Ms Barbara Byng
Financial Controller	Ms Arlene Richards
Assistant Financial Controller	Ms Marianne Mohr
Office Manager	Ms Sinead Buckley / Ms Mary Milevski
Information & Referral: Senior Administration Officer	Ms Silvia Ruano
Information & Referral: Administration Officer	Ms Helen Short
Rural Projects Team Leader	Mr Alex Burns
Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP	Rose Oku / Gerda Maeder
New England SGP Worker (Tamworth)	Mr Home Phanoraj
New England SGP Worker (Armidale)	Ms Judith Roberts
New England SGP Worker (Inverell)	Ms Daisy Brown
Links To Learning Coordinator	Mr Chris Hudson
Aged Care Projects Team Leader/	
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator	Ms Slavica (Sue) Hristov
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 2	Ms Lupe Fonua
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 3 / Tax Help Officer	Ms Tima 'Oto
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service	Ms Christine Follett / Ms Tima 'Oto
CVS Coordinator	Ms Enza Di Stefano
Multicultural Social Support Service Senior Coordinator	Ms Sandra Wingrave
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator	Ms Olivia Fuente
Multicultural Social Support Service	
Office Manager/ Administration Officer	Ms Sharlene Huber/ Ms Trudy Wahl
African Projects Team Leader / Community Projects Officer	Mr Michael Adderley
Volunteers Coordinator	Mr Michael Freund
African Welfare Worker	Mr Simon (Major) Pabek
African Youth Worker	Mr Marial Fieg
African Parenting Assistant	Ms Amer Manyoun
African Family Support Workers (Families First)	Mr Zachary Karithi / Mr Mohamed Kamara/ Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye / Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Welfare Projects Team Leader/Filipino Welfare Worker	Ms Petrona Kelly
Multicultural Family Worker (Families First)	Ms Miza Torlakovic
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Samoan) /	
Tax Help Officer/EAPA	Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Tongan)	Ms Sara Stankovic / Ms Lydia Manusiu
Russian Welfare Worker	Ms Elena Ferguson
Thai Welfare Worker	Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Migrant & Refugee Women's Worker	Ms Zenaida Edmunds

MINUTES OF THE 23rd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED (FORMERLY THE MIGRANT RESOURCE CENTRE OF NEWCASTLE & HUNTER REGION LIMITED) HELD AT NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES ON THURSDAY 29 NOVEMBER 2007 AT 11.00AM.

Present: as per list attached.

1. H Chan welcomed everyone present & noted that this was the 1st AGM following the name change to NSS. He thanked everyone for their attendance on behalf of the NSS Management Committee.

2. **APOLOGIES:** Zoran Vasiljevic
Irina Lupish

3. **MINUTES OF THE 2006 AGM: MINUTES ACCEPTED:**

Proposed: S Young

Seconded: I Klopčic

4. **BUSINESS ARISING:**

V Walsh clarified the agency's progress in relation to the DGR application, stating that only some projects qualified as eligible funds. A further change to the constitution may be required. Honorary Legal Advisor Michael Walsh continues to work on our application and we hope for more progress over the coming months.

Team structures are working well however there is a concern that some Team Leaders may be overloaded. Further refinements will be made to the structure but the process has been largely beneficial.

DIAC consultant Ian Johns has retired, new consultant is Intho Taylor.

ASIC has accepted our changes to the constitution, and the change of name was registered on 16th January 2007 – takes a while to get used to the new name.

5. **PRESENTATION OF REPORTS:**

Chairman's Report: H Chan - Report tabled & accepted as read.

V Walsh – Centre Director: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- V Walsh wanted to endorse statements made in her report re the Financial management of the agency, noting that the Financial Controller is doing a superb job in the changed environment. The appointment of an Assistant Financial Controller has been a very good outcome as we need to maintain our accountability.
- Some sad goodbyes this year to Paul Sidebottom & Ann Dupree & also some new staff to be welcomed.
- A good year in 2007

REPORTS OF THE SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM

I Lupish – Migration Agent, Community Project Officer, Russian Welfare & L Tantos – Deputy Director, Migration Agent: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- L Tantos said the demand for Migration Agent services continued & that I Lupish has travelled extensively this year.

REPORTS OF THE RURAL TEAM

A Burns – SGP Rural Support Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- CSSS is now called Settlement Grant Program (SGP) & the two projects which formerly existed in the New England area have now been combined into one entity.
- Some changes to the focus of the Links to Learning project in Tamworth – now extended to early school leavers. Project now also covers the wider Northern area.
- C Hudson is now the locum for the Links to Learning as Michelle Steele is on maternity leave.

M Torlakovic – SGP Welfare Outreach Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- M Torlakovic is shortly moving to the Families First role (Welfare Team) having done a wonderful job as an SGP worker.
- Two new positions will now cover Hunter SGP, as a shared role.

J Roberts SGP New England: Report tabled & accepted as read.

H Phanoraj SGP New England: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- A Burns remarked that both workers in the New England SGP were still learning their roles .

M Steele Links to Learning Project Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read

- Very difficult to get this project established in this area. Funding has been received for another year.

REPORTS OF THE AGED CARE TEAM

S Hristov & L Fonua & T 'Oto – Community Aged Care Packages: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- S Hristov thanked the other CACP coordinators for their assistance during her husbands' recent illness.
- S Hristov welcomed new team members Enza Di Stefano & Sandra Wingrave

C Follett – Hunter Multicultural Respite Service: Report tabled & accepted as read.

E Di Stefano – Community Visitors Scheme: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- E Di Stefano said she felt very welcomed by staff & the wonderful CVS volunteers.

S Wingrave, O Fuente & S Huber – HACC Multicultural Social Support Service – Central Coast: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Project is going from strength to strength.

REPORTS OF THE AFRICAN TEAM

T 'Oto – Refugee & Humanitarian Entrant Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

S Pabek – CSSS/SGP Sudanese & African Communities Support Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Very high numbers of issues being dealt with.

M Fieg – CSSS African Youth Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Many problems with young Africans in schools, complex cases & co-ordination between agencies is vital. V Walsh stated that the workers' efforts were to be commended & the Committee confirmed that they are aware of the issues being faced & are looking at options to provide the best services on limited resources.

I Nduwamunga & Z Karithi – African Family Support Workers: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- 3 communities being looked after by this project
- Poor educational background, high need for English language services, translation etc.
- Ongoing problems – much work to be done.

C Johnston – Refugee Orientation DVD- Project Officer: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- C Johnston remarked that the magnitude of work would not be possible without the support received from other staff. A very useful resource.

P Kelly – Filipino Welfare Project: Report tabled & accepted as read.

D Wijewardene – Multicultural Family Support Project – Families First: Report tabled & accepted as read.

M Adderley– New Land New Laws Project: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Project going very well & is receiving huge support from the legal community.
- Thanks to the African workers for their support.

STAFF REPORTS: ACCEPTED:

Proposer: T Mills Evers
Seconded: S Young

FINANCIAL REPORTS:

- Mr Mark O'Connor from Cutcher & Neale presented a brief report on the NSS's financial dealings over the past 12 months. He acknowledged that the reports are now in a different format to reflect International Accounting standards. Administration costs have reduced. He concluded saying that the report reflected a growing centre.

FINANCIAL REPORTS: ACCEPTED:

Proposed: I Klopacic
Seconded: A Kizeweter

6. APPOINTMENT OF COMPANY AUDITORS:

Proposed: L Tantos
Seconded: T Mills Evers

- H Chan confirmed Cutcher & Neale to be retained as the Centre's Auditor for 2008.

7. ELECTION OF DIRECTORS FOR NSS BOARD OF MANAGEMENT

1. Mr William Simanowsky
2. Ms Trudy Mills-Evers
3. Ms Alina Kizeweter
4. Ms Sania Young
5. Mr Zoran Vasiljevic
6. Mr Henry Chan
7. Fthr Nicholas Zervas
8. Mr Ivan Klopčic
9. Mr John McLennan
10. Mr Biko Syongoh

The 10 nominations were duly elected as the 2008 NSS Board of Management.

8. GENERAL BUSINESS

- H Chan offered the appreciation of the Committee to the Administration wing on the production of the Annual Report. He also thanked DIMA consultant Ian Johns for his interest & consultancy help throughout his tenure.
- V Walsh reported a growth in the Russian Welfare area however no apparent funding to service the needs of this community. H Chan said the committee looked forward to progress on these things.

Signed at the Annual General Meeting held on 29th November 2007 at NSS premises.

Henry Chan
CHAIRMAN

Meeting closed at 12.40pm

ATTENDANCE LIST AGM 29 NOVEMBER 2007

	Name	Community/Group/Organisation
1	Fr. Nicholas Zervas	NSS Management Committee/ Greek Community of Newcastle
2	Ivan Klopčič	NSS Management Committee/ Slovenian Community of Newcastle
3	Sania Young	NSS Management Committee/ Russian Community
4	Denise Hodgson	Centrelink
5	Christine Follett	NSS
6	Tima Oto	NSS/ Tongan Community
7	Sue Hristov	NSS
8	Sara Stankovic	NSS/ Tongan Community
9	Juanita Loli	NSS/ Samoan Community
10	Lupe Fonua	NSS
11	John McLennan	Treasurer: NSS Management Committee
12	Natalie Dobinson	Cutcher & Neale
13	Alina Kizeweter	Secretary/ Polish Community
14	Henry Chan	Chairman: NSS Management Committee
15	William Simanowsky	Vice Chairman: NSS Management Committee
16	Elena Ferguson	NSS
17	Zenaida Edmunds	NSS/ MNC
18	Pet Kelly	NSS
19	Enza Distefano	NSS
20	Sinead Buckley	NSS
21	Michael Adderley	NSS
22	Sharlene Huber	NSS/ MSSS
23	Sandra Wingrave	NSS/ MSSS
24	A. Greer	NSS/ MSSS (placement)
25	Alex Burns	NSS
26	Miza Torlakovic	NSS
27	Marianne Mohr	NSS
28	Arlene Richards	NSS
29	Simon Pabek	NSS
30	Marial Fieg	NSS
31	Lulu Tantos	NSS
32	Silvia Ruano	NSS
33	Zachary Ekandi	NSS
34	Trudy Mills-Evers	Assist.Treasurer: NSS Management Committee
35	Nellie Srisurapon	NSS
36	Renee McLean	NSS
37	Violetta Walsh	NSS

OVERVIEW OF 2008

NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

Funding Partnerships throughout 2008

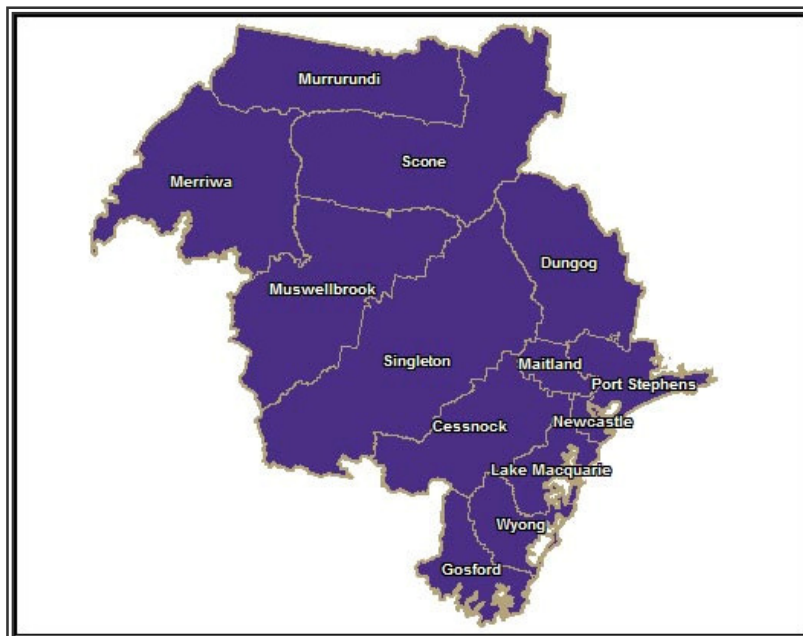
- Department of Immigration & Citizenship (DIAC)
- NSW Department of Community Services (DoCS)
- Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing
- NSW Department of Ageing Disability & Home Care (DADHC)
- Community Development Support Expenditure (Registered Clubs NSW)
- Department of Families, Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs (FaHCSIA)

Clients by Ethnic Background

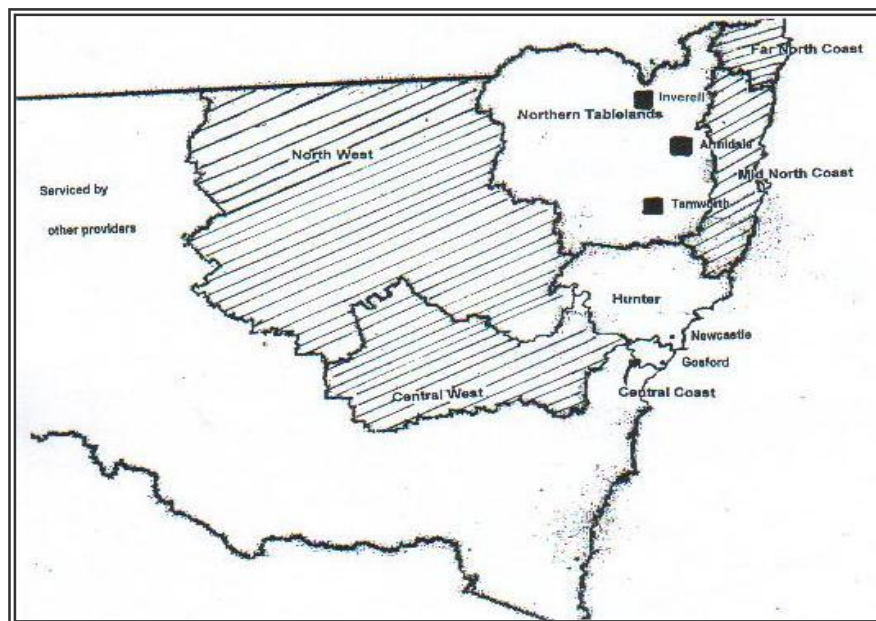
Afghanistan	Fiji	Liberia	Russia
Albania	Finland	Malaysia	Serbia
Algeria	France	Mauritania	Slovenia
Argentina	Germany	Montenegro	Sierra Leone
Australia	Greece	Macedonia	Singapore
Austria	Guatemala	Mexico	South Africa
Bangladesh	Honduras	Morocco	Sri Lanka
Bosnia	Hungary	Nepal	Spain
Botswana	Hong Kong	Netherlands	Sudan
Brazil	India	New Zealand	Sweden
Burundi	Indonesia	Nigeria	Switzerland
Canada	Ireland	Norway	Syria
Chile	Iran	Panama	Tahiti
China	Iraq	Pakistan	Taiwan
Colombia	Italy	Papua New Guinea	Thailand
Congo (DRC)	Japan	Paraguay	Tonga
Croatia	Jordan	Persia	Turkey
Cyprus	Kazakhstan	Peru	Ukraine
Czech Republic	Kenya	Poland	Uruguay
Dominican Republic	Korea	Portugal	USA
East Timor	Kuwait	Philippines	Vietnam
Egypt	Lebanon	Romania	Venezuela
El Salvador	Latvia	Rwanda	
England	Lithuania	Scotland	

OUR SERVICE REGIONS & OFFICE LOCATIONS

HUNTER OUTREACH



OFFICE LOCATIONS & SERVICE REGIONS



Areas serviced by NSS offices at Hamilton
Gosford, Armidale, Tamworth & Inverell



Areas serviced by NSS outreach workers



Chairman's Report **Henry Chan**

As we fast approach the end of a busy and productive year, it is good to reflect on the achievements that have occurred in this, now the second year of our new identity as Northern Settlement Services Ltd.

I think it is well worth re-iterating here the objectives which, since our establishment as a Migrant Resource Centre, have always been our guiding principles, but which now are part and parcel of our constitution - to directly deliver services to ensure the relief from hardship, distress, misfortune and poverty of those refugees and migrants settling in our catchment area, and to work towards the successful settlement and long term welfare of such refugees and migrants.

As you peruse this Annual report, you will be impressed I think, with the range and diversity of those services we are providing, from delivering programs to African refugee young people, to facilitating high quality home based care to the frail aged among our migrant communities. But apart from our refugee and aged care work, all our activities target disadvantaged migrants, and seek to improve life circumstances and to enhance life opportunity for the most vulnerable members of our community.

You will also note that our organization has continued to expand its service delivery footprint throughout the vast geographic area that we call our backyard. Our hub in north west NSW now comprises Tamworth, Armidale and Inverell, while the Central Coast site, home to our Multicultural Support Service, for older clients, is also increasingly used by our field staff undertaking outreach services, and looks set to grow even further.

Our HQ in Hamilton is also experiencing growth through a number of additional partnerships with various funding bodies which have allowed us to meet gaps in services that we have identified together with our communities. I mention just a few - the DIAC funded Complex Case Support which targets refugees experiencing critical problems in their settlement; the Citizenship Support Service which aims to help the most needy to prepare for the citizenship test; the NSW Clubs funding Homework Centres for African refugee students struggling at school, and last but not least the Area Assistance Scheme funding for Domestic Violence support and education for vulnerable CALD women.

But we are also very proud of our partnership with Penola House, operated just across the road by the Josephite Refugee Service, and which is proving a wonderful haven for our refugee mothers and their children, and a great environment for some of our refugees.

All in all a year of which we can all be proud.

As always I want to express my appreciation for the dedicated and hardworking team around me, fellow Board members and staff and volunteers, which makes our organisation such an inspiring work place.



Director's Report

Violetta Walsh OAM

It is never business as usual in this organisation, and it is precisely its dynamism and variety that keeps some of us here, even though by some calculations, we have passed our "use by" date. And of course we keep being told that mature age workers are valued and valuable- though I would not like to test the market at this stage!

So, despite an occasional thought to be somewhere else, I am continuing in the work I know and love. And it has been an interesting and challenging year, spent overseeing the consolidation and expansion of the services we offer to our target population, as well of course as trying to respond strategically to the service demands that have come to our attention related to our target population.

The people we serve remain a combination of people from non English speaking background- the African refugees who continue to arrive, albeit in more modest numbers, into our area, the disadvantaged migrants, especially women, who experience difficulty and hardship in their settlement in a new country, and aged migrants and their carers striving to remain in their homes as long as possible. The diversity in this cohort continues to amaze us all. Our records show that we have provided services for people from 94 different ethnic backgrounds.

The reports of our staff detail the agency's activities and projects and provide a sense of the breadth and depth of our work with this diverse population; please take the time to peruse them.

Overall, a key influence on the activities of this agency has been funding, both anticipated - i.e. from our usual sources, and the "windfalls," less expected, coming from successful submissions to various funding bodies. Whatever the source, all of it has been necessary and welcome, to allow us not only to continue the important work of providing basic settlement services to those arrivals in need of a helping hand.

There are several I want to identify specifically, because of the boost they have provided to our ability to serve better two especially vulnerable groups among our client base- African young people, and women and children caught up in domestic violence and the accompanying outcomes of poverty, and often homelessness.

Through the Area Assistance Scheme, we have received a grant to provide domestic violence support and education to CALD (culturally and linguistically diverse) women, which is particularly welcome by our caseworkers whose caseloads feature domestic violence in alarming numbers.

Clubs NSW through their CDSE Program have once again funded our efforts to provide remedial education support to young African refugee school students, who are entering our school system with very little prior education, and are experiencing significant problems keeping up, and achieving the potential they have as future Australians. The funding, from 4 local clubs allows us to conduct homework centres in several locations where some of our wonderful volunteers provide one on one support and tuition to students. We see this (and those clubs agreed with us) as truly an investment for the future to ensure that no one is left behind in this land of opportunity.

Another very exciting project that has come our way is the Citizenship Support Project to prepare to sit for the Citizenship test. Some groups need special help, refugees, people with literacy problems to present themselves for what can be a daunting experience. The project has to cover a very large geographic area, all the way out west to Dubbo and Orange, northwest to Lightning Ridge, NSW Central Coast and of course all the way up the NSW coast to the Queensland border. It has been heart warming to see the obvious joy of the successful candidates and their success certainly makes the project worthwhile.

The agency was also successful in winning a Department of Immigration (DIAC) tender to provide Complex Case Support ie, to assist newly arrived refugee clients who experience particular challenges in their settlement above and beyond the more routine services which all new refugees have in a new country. We have not yet had occasion to deliver these services but it is reassuring to know that when the time comes, we will be resourced to do what has to be done, without short-changing our other services.

Briefly, in other project areas, several of our very important basic services were refunded by DIAC - our Refugee youth project, the migrant and refugee Women's project and our Hunter Outreach project which provides services to refugees and disadvantaged migrants in the mid and upper Hunter. Our aged services are operating very efficiently and effectively, both here and on the Central Coast, and we look forward to developing them as opportunities arise. Our communities are ageing, and presenting needs that earlier were not even on the radar.

All our teams are working well, - Welfare, Rural, African and Special Projects and the team structures have certainly proved to be as effective as we anticipated.

The year has been full of interesting highlights- visits by ministers –Linda Burney DOCS, in June and in September, by the new Minister of Immigration, Senator Chris Evans who spent some time with us hearing about our concerns and our aspirations, and leaving a lasting impression of a decent intelligent and humane man genuinely wanting to make a difference in a difficult portfolio.

There were also the inevitable goodbyes to Chris Follett, and Sinead Buckley –and the saddest goodbye of all to a long time friend and colleague Ann Dupree, due to a terminal illness.

As we fast approach the end of another year, it is incumbent on me to thank my wonderful colleagues who really lighten a Director's load. Everyone in the organisation is a vital contributing part of an amazing and productive whole: there is so much talent and commitment not only under this roof, but under all the other roofs which house our staff-in Armidale, Tamworth, Inverell, and Bateau Bay on the Central Coast.



SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM

Ms Lulu Tantos
Assistant Director
Registered Migration Agent
Special Projects Team Leader

Ms Irina Lupish
Registered Migration Agent

Ms Barbara Byng
Citizenship Support



Immigration Advice & Assistance Scheme

Lulu Tantos (Reg.#0318123) & **Irina Lupish** (Reg.#0428428)

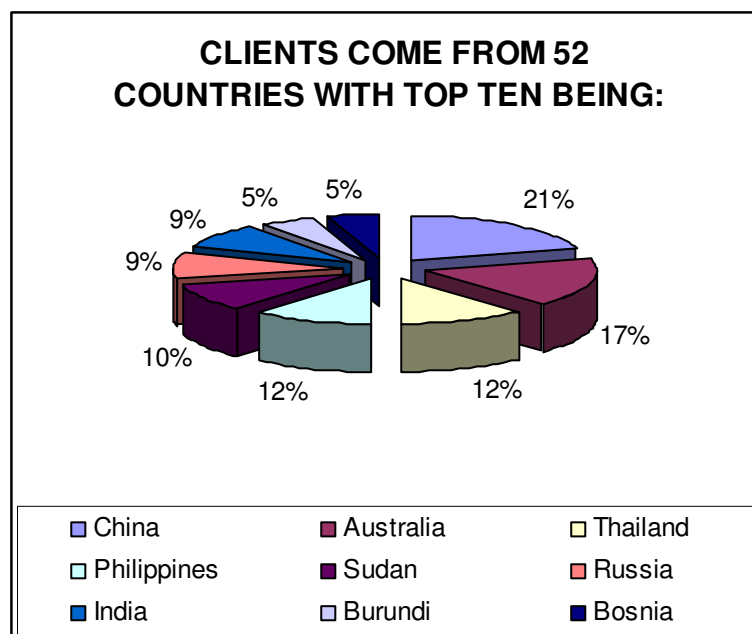
Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Northern Settlement Services Limited continues to provide a highly valued immigration service, providing professional migration advice and application assistance under the IAAAS to eligible, needy clients in Newcastle and the Hunter region, Central Coast, North Coast, and Central West.

Persons eligible for the IAAAS include all protection visa applicants in detention, and the most disadvantaged protection visa applicants and other visa applicants or sponsors in the community who are in financial hardship and disadvantaged due to their:

- cultural background
- literacy skills
- location
- physical or psychological disability resulting from past torture/trauma; or
- physical or psychological harm resulting from family violence.

This year has been a busy year for our two Registered Migration Agents. In total, 519 clients from 52 different countries have been provided with face to face advice and assistance and over 1200 clients assisted by telephone.



Telephone advice has also been given to 181 clients in rural and regional areas including Lightning Ridge, Coffs Harbour, Dubbo, Orange, Bathurst, Balina, Byron Bay, Moree and the Central Coast.

As part of our IAAAS contractual obligations with the Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC) outreach services to disadvantaged clients have also been conducted in Singleton, Coffs Harbor, Yamba, Lightning Ridge, Tamworth, Inverell and Armidale.

Throughout the year the service has been complemented by quarterly outreach visits to the premises conducted by experienced Departmental Officers from the DIAC Parramatta office. This service has been invaluable in providing disadvantaged clients in our region with the opportunity to meet and discuss face-to-face their individual needs and concerns.

Sincere thanks are extended to our Board of Management, our 'fearless leader' Violetta and to the remainder of the wonderful staff at NSS for their invaluable support, guidance and friendship throughout the past year.



Citizenship Support Grants Program

Barbara Byng

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The program provides a service to Newcastle and the Hunter Valley, the Central Coast, Central West, Mid North Coast, Far North Coast and the North West.

The Citizenship Support Service is a pilot program running for twelve months beginning July 2008. It is a free service for all permanent residents wishing to become Australian citizens.

The aim of the project is to support people, who are permanent residents in their application for citizenship; this includes English speaking as well as non-English speaking people.

Assistance is available to help people prepare for the test which includes:

- advice on the nature of the test and the process of becoming a citizen.
- What to expect when sitting for the test and advice on eligibility for a standard or assisted test.
- Support with understanding the information in the booklet "Becoming an Australian Citizen."
- Referral to other services which may support their process and assistance to book the test.

Help is also available with basic computer skills with a practice test and test questions.

The majority of my clients would be classed as disadvantaged for the following reasons;

- non-English speaking background
- literacy in main language of country of origin
- remote location
- psychological disability from past trauma or torture or harm resulting from family violence.

These clients need intensive assistance and hold a lot of fear about their ability to become Australian citizens.

Clients come from African countries, Thailand, Philippines, Korea, China, Burma, Samoa, Macedonia, England, Italy, Palestine, East Timor, Russia and Germany.

I began working with Northern Settlement Service as the Facilitator for this project in August 2008. My first job was to advertise the service to as many people as possible with such a wide geographical area I made use of all avenues. Word of mouth also played a part and I was soon booking appointments to give people information, assess their needs and offer assistance.

The next task was to design a program which would offer assistance to a diverse group of people whose ability with English and particular needs differed from person to person, and then to develop the resources that cover a range of learning styles and differing needs.

Given the complexity of needs I took a four level approach;

- Distance support for those who have good English skills, study independently and then come to me for practice tests and other support needs.
- Classes running once a week for two hours each session, for those people of mixed backgrounds who have moderate support needs,
- Small groups running weekly for those with high support needs and,
- one-to-one support for those who need intensive assistance.

I use visual aids, props, reading and speaking the information from the book. With the help of a volunteer we are making flash cards and a game about citizenship.

The outreach service takes a different form, assessed on need. In Coffs Harbour for instance, the need is high, so there will be an intensive two-week program with nightly classes, groups and one-to-one service daily. In other areas I will look at using email, telephone and where possible some face-to-face time.

I now have clients in Newcastle, the Hunter, the Central Coast and Coffs Harbour.

To date, four of my clients have taken the Citizenship Test and all four have passed opening the way for them to make their application for citizenship. Two are from Sudan, one from Liberia and one from Mozambique. Eleven people are booked in for the test over the next two months.

I have fifty clients, with twenty eight in the African humanitarian stream. Nineteen of those need special one-to-one support.

The response from clients is very favourable and most express how much this service is helping them, not only with the process of becoming an Australian citizen but giving them hope and relieving some of their fear.



RURAL TEAM

Mr Alex Burns
Rural Projects Team Leader
Rural Support Project

Ms Rose Oku & Ms Gerda Maeder
Settlement Support Workers
Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Grants Program

Ms Judith Roberts
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Armidale)

Mr Home Phanoraj
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Tamworth)

Ms Daisy Brown
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Inverell)
(Unreported)

Mr Chris Hudson
Coordinator
Links To Learning Community Grants Program
(Tamworth)



Rural Support Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

Alex Burns

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Introduction

This project provides team leadership, assistance, mentoring and resourcing to NSS and other rural SGP Workers and direct support to DIAC funded SGP projects who mainly provide support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees, family and other permanent visa holders who have low English language proficiency and may be experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

This support is provided to projects encountering new arrivals in a range of diverse locations on the North Coast (Lismore, Woolgoolga and Coffs Harbour); Mid North Coast (Manning Valley and Port Macquarie); New England (Armidale, Tamworth and Inverell); Central Western and Far Western (Orange, Bathurst, Dubbo and Lightning Ridge); Central Coast (Wyoming); and in the Hunter Statistical Division (Newcastle, Singleton, Scone, Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens and Maitland). The potential client group comprises some 5000 new arrivals of which 22 percent are refugees and humanitarian entrants. The growth of the refugee population in Northern and Western NSW reflects two forms of settlement. The first of these is the settlement of people on the 202 Visa, where family and volunteer settlement support groups have been the reason for the arrival of refugees in different rural towns. The second process is secondary settlement. This is a self generated settlement process by refugees and humanitarian entrants settlement in some towns has occurred as this population has sought access to the range of local industries such as employment in regional meatworks, chicken processing plants and as harvesters of fruit. While these are not the bulk of the migrants settling in the regional areas where this project operates this group is the group which is confronted by most settlement issues and the one that most advice and mentoring is required from this project.

Achievements

Casework and Orientation Support

Although the focus of this project is mentoring and working to achieve better access to services for new arrivals in regional areas, it has provided some Casework as this project reinforces other projects to support their casework, including some direct casework.

Table 1 provides information on the project's DIAC Online Settlement Client Activity Recording (OSCAR) work.

Table 1: OSCAR For the Rural Support Grant 2007-2008

First Long Contact	Subsequent Contact	Short Contacts	Group Sessions
20	25	32	35

Direct Work with Rural Based Projects

Contact and support to the individual rural based SGP projects continues to vary as a greater amount of time during the year was given to the Settlement grants projects managed by the NSS. This is shown in **Table 2** below and can better be understood, as several of these projects are located in the same base as the Rural Support project. NSS has SGP project workers based in Armidale, Tamworth, in Newcastle and in the Hunter Valley. Part of the work plan requirement of the Rural Support project this year, was to establish a new SGP position in Inverell and this occurred in February with the appointment of Daisy Brown.

What the table doesn't show is what the contact with each SGP project covered and again this was varied as it related to immediate support by projects which sought to be guided in dealing with individual clients, the preparation of specific group work with clients, support to work with other agencies, follow up with actions raised at various interagencies to which the SGP projects managed or attended, providing cultural awareness support, selecting new SGP project workers for some projects -(Sandra Moon at Coffs Harbour, Colleen McGowan at Manning Valley, Daisy Brown, Monique Van Toor at Bathurst) and improving services when working or going into partnership with a particular government or non-government agencies. In several cases this meant using identified issues to create or raise agency awareness. Among these continued to be the issue of services not using interpreters when needed. This of course led on to families finding themselves in financial debt with some agencies as they were not informed of what the service provider required of the family, being threatened with eviction and so on. In many other instances the SGP workers had to engage services, which did not understand their responsibilities to refugees and migrants through legislative requirement as with the NSW EAPS or with the Commonwealth's responsibility for providing services in a multicultural Australia.

Table 2: An indication of the interaction the Rural Support project has with rural based CSSS/SGP projects July 2007 - June 2008

Projects	Contacts	Projects	Contacts
Central Coast	71	Hunter Outreach	148
Clarence Valley	75	MRC African	101
Lismore	67	Lightning Ridge	89
Bathurst	85	New England (<i>Tamworth, Armidale & Inverell</i>)	485
Dubbo	35	Orange	64
Coffs Harbour	62	African Youth	86
St Vincent de Paul			
Newcastle Women's project	87	Manning Valley	54

Other Work

Other work was eclectic and included supporting other agencies in improving the access to their services, participating in panels, advisory committees and forums such as the DoCS state Ethnic Affairs Advisory group, the DADHC Hunter Central Coast regional group, the Hunter Consultative Water forum, the NSW Hunter DET. Equity meeting and so on. Managing, including convening and resourcing all the regional multicultural interagencies and networks in northern NSW— the New England, Central West, North Coast, Mid North Coast, Newcastle, Central Coast and Hunter Rural forums. Altogether, a busy but productive year.



Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Grants Program

Rose Oku & Gerda Maeder *(now resigned)*

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP project, funded by Dept of Immigration and Citizenship provides support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees and migrants, especially women who are experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement. 3 project workers, Miza Torlakovic, Rose Oku and Gerda Maeder, managed this project through the year. Miza transferred to another project in December 2007 and Rose and Gerda became the project workers at that time with Rose looking after the upper area of the Hunter and Lake Macquarie and Gerda managing the Port Stephens area.

Casework

During the year the project provide much face to face casework for the client group and especially the provision of support for women in diverse parts of the Hunter to attend Family Court, access English and employment training courses and to attend Centrelink, community health programs and tenancy services. **Table 1** provides a picture of this work.

Table 1:

Casework and Group Work Sessions for the Hunter Outreach SGP project 2007-2008

First Contact	Subsequent Contact	Short casework	Group Work Sessions
76	177	218	25

Major Issues Identified during work with the Client group

Many individual issues were raised through the Casework while other issues arose with group work and information sessions. These can be categorised as issues relating to housing and tenancy – lack of accommodation, high rent, tenancy transfers, repairs during tenancy; Health, and in particular Women's health matters; inability to access English language programs and classes in areas like Singleton, Muswellbrook and Cessnock; problems with Centrelink, benefits and loss of the conditions associated with benefits if one partner obtains work; Immigration and visa problems such as Family reunion, the skilled visa and the changes to Citizenship; Employment and the cost of childcare, training opportunities through job network, limited TAFE outreach courses lack of employment and poor transport and social isolation.

Group Work

Information sessions were held throughout the year in partnership with Community Health, Centrelink, the Tenancy Advice Service, Immigration advice with the NSS Migration Agents, developing Volunteers and community group participation with the support of the Rural Support project and work with the Department of Housing.

Networking and other Forums

Much of the success of the project has been due to its ability to network with other organisations. This offered good client outcomes through the project workers knowledge about specific services through the relationships this networking developed. Other networking through formal meetings, interagencies and other forums meant that the project workers were well able to share information on the target group, refer sensitive case work to familiar services and to develop a strong base on issues that impacted on the new arrival clients. The network included managing 3 meetings of the Hunter Rural multicultural network. These were held in Cessnock, Kurri Kurri and Singleton. At one of these, Maitland Council addressed the Network on its Social Plan so as to improve service delivery to the migrant community in the Maitland area and on its work with African Refugees. In addition, I have participated in the Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens, Cessnock, Upper Hunter and Singleton local government area Interagencies. Other forums included: the Cessnock Family Insight graduation, the Hunter New England Area Health Mental Health Multicultural Access Committee and the quarterly Centrelink forum.

Training

A major area of importance is the continued development of skills to help in delivering the project. Appropriate training for each project worker was encouraged and was particularly important to the new project workers. In November, Miza was encouraged to develop her skills on working in the child protection area and so she attended the conference on Child Abuse at the Gold Coast. Training for the new project workers included OSCAR training with DIAC, Networking, working on the frontline with clients, family harmony awareness, Community Development, working with male migrants, healthy living for families and the 3 day Rural DIAC Conference.

Altogether it has been a busy year with good outcomes for the project's refugee and migrant client group.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Armidale)

Judith Roberts

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged people, mainly refugees and migrant women by providing settlement information, referring them to other agencies where appropriate, building their capacity to become independent and confident in working with mainstream agencies and services. Further as humanitarian entrants face multiple barriers to settlement and high levels of socio-economic disadvantage the project also works to ensure that services are accessible and equitable to this target population. Most of the client group consist of female humanitarian entrants who are single parents with large families. This group of clients has required intensive settlement support.

Client Services

Client issues identified in the work of this project include access to ESL classes, lack of provision of interpreters by many services, homelessness, employment, transport, debt issues, access to driving lessons, health access mainly due to transport problems and lack of knowledge of the health system, family relationship breakdowns, access and equity, access to childcare.

Table 1: is a record of the client work of this project where OSCAR 1 reflects new clients, OSCAR 2 is follow up work with clients, OSCAR 3 relates to general information sought from the project and OSCAR 4 is the number of group presentations and group work of the project.

Table 1: Client Statistics

Type	Number
OSCAR 1	27
OSCAR 2	497
OSCAR 3	52
OSCAR 4	60

Many of the women clients face added challenges as sole parents due to their husband's return to their country of origin, death, or family breakdown. Due to these women's family responsibilities attendance at TAFE is often irregular which then impacts on their English language acquisition. Consequently, most have very low levels of English which means their integration is also much more difficult. The main issues for the young men are employment, access to driving lessons, housing and access to ESL entitlements. This group had many participants in the Together, Together Project with good outcomes.

Another client group regularly seen are the ESL class participants at TAFE; this group includes new arrival Filipinos, Chinese, Sudanese, Nepalese, Afghanis, Iranians and others all will low levels of English. Through this contact assistance was provided to organise swimming lessons for Refugee women in Armidale as well as providing an opportunity for students to have access to information sessions supported by this project.

The Tamworth Migrant Women's Support Group is another significant part of the project. The needs of the group are met through informal means i.e. Craft activities and social outings and through visits by health professionals or the like. The Sudanese female community has received consistent support in areas such as education, health, transport difficulties, household management including living skills and financial support required through referrals to budget counsellors, and Centrelink support. A valuable partnership has been achieved with Hunter New England Health. This has included the provision of 2 dietary sessions and then a Multicultural Lunch. This provided the women with an opportunity to showcase their skills in traditional food preparation to while learning about methods of healthy food preparation.

We have also attended outings during school holidays such as picnics and a trip to the Refugee Health Nurse's Girl Guide Camp at Kootingal. Country Energy provided an information session to the group, which was well received. The refugee's Christmas party was an excellent opportunity for the women's group and their children to mix with the wider community. Other issues identified with this group have been access to childcare, budgeting, family relationships and child safety. This group is also supported by our partnership with the Tamworth Women's Refuge and a very dedicated NSS volunteer.

Tamworth Case Work The women's group in Tamworth continues to require an amount of casework with settlement needs that go beyond the group sessions. Many of the women have required intensive support to access financial counselling, Brighter Futures Early Intervention, and general living skills. Constant promotion of interpreters is required for clients.

Outreach to Inverell Since Daisy Brown was appointed in Inverell early in 2008, I have supported Daisy. During Daisy's maternity leave I have travelled to Inverell on a regular basis. I have made visits to clients in Inverell where possible and have liaised with the Inverell Sanctuary Group to provide settlement support to new arrivals in Inverell. Some of the issues through this work have included lack of interpreter usage, lack of access to appropriate mental health support and general social isolation.

Meetings and Committee representation The project is involved in a range of networking through attendance at various meetings. These include, New England Multicultural Interagency, Transcultural Mental Health project, New England Area Health Multicultural Access Committee, Community Drug Action Team, Armidale Interagency, Inverell Interagency, Sanctuary Armidale, HNEH Refugee Health Meetings and DET New England Region Equity Committee .

Community Events The Together, Together project meant a close relationship with Armidale Dumaresq Council. This was a public speaking project with participants from the migrant, refugee, Indigenous and wider community. The project ended in October 2007. In Refugee Week the Tamworth Migrant Women's Group travelled to Nundle for a picnic for Refugee Week. This event was supported by the Tamworth Women's Refuge and was attended by refugees, migrants and clients of the refuge. In Armidale the project worked collaboratively with TAFE and Armidale Sanctuary to hold an event in Armidale that was attended by over 300 people from a broad cross-section of the Armidale Community.

An event in Inverell was organised by Daisy Brown with 80 attendees-this was a very well attended barbecue with refugees and the wider community attending including Sanctuary members.

During the year the project worker attended a range of training to build skills and knowledge.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Tamworth)

Home Phanoraj

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The Tamworth base of the New England Settlement Grant Project (SGP) is a 3 day a week service and provides support services to highly disadvantaged people, mainly refugee men and women and their families living and working in the Tamworth area. It offers settlement information, referral to other agencies where appropriate, building their capacity to become independent and confident in seeking service and support and working with other agencies and services to ensure that services are accessible and equitable to this target population in the first five year period of their arrival.

The Tamworth work addresses the settlement issues of isolation, lack of supportive networks and accessibility to the services. It assists the Refugee and migrant community's development and promotes a sense of self-identity, determination, belonging and motivation to participate with the broader community. Through promotion, the project also raises the awareness among the mainstream service providers to become more responsive to the needs of the new arrivals and encourages the broader community to be responsive to needs of the Refugee and Migrant community in the Tamworth area.

Table 1 is a summary of the clients by background who have been assisted by the project. As will be noted the vast number of the client group were people from Sudan, refugees who have sought work in the industries found in Tamworth or have wanted a better (safer) environment for their children.

Table 1: Clients by Birthplace Background

Background of Clients	Number	Background of Clients	Number
Sudanese	83	Vietnamese	9
Liberian	2	Eritrean	1
Zimbabwean	4	Thai	16
Iraqi	3	India	13
Malaysia	3	Chinese	15
Laos	4	Filipino	15
Dutch	1	Total	169

Settlement issues

The settlement related issues are varied and include: access to renting of private accommodation, a lack of understanding of what public housing means and how to access the same, employment and temporary employment and living skills for employment, an ongoing need for English language learning, home tutoring, support to complete the School and Higher School certificate and school enrolment, Online study, becoming an Australian citizen, migration and sponsoring relatives and other family members, childcare, health and dental checks, driving training and overseas driver license conversion, using local transport services, developing social skills, issues on domestic violence and child welfare, sporting group development, school holiday programs and so forth.

Accommodation issues

There were three identifiable issues that constrain the success of refugees in their search for suitable accommodations and these are: the record of the applicant as a good tenant; any accumulated debt by the applicant and the third relates to available tenancies. Currently, African refugee community members are supported to access short-term rental accommodation but it's proven to be very difficult to find long-term accommodation of any condition to rent. As a result, many are forced to share crowded accommodation.

Employment opportunities

In Tamworth, the abattoirs and chicken processing plants are the two major sources of employment that continue to attract the African (male) community to the area. This year, there has been a change in this work however, with an increase in numbers of Sudanese workers in the local Chicken processing plant over the abattoirs. Small numbers of the Sudanese leave the area only to return to find seasonal harvesting work in the Blueberry farms around Coffs Harbour. Other migrant communities, and especially Filipino women are employed more widely in chicken hatchery plants, nursing and aged care, while the Chinese, Thai, Indian, Lebanese and Vietnamese new arrivals tend to find work in local restaurants, catering business and service stations.

Networking

As part of the New England SGP, the Tamworth work has also developed a good working relationship with government and non-government organisations in the area including the local volunteer groups, Tamworth Regional Council, Tamworth Community collage, DoCS, Youth services, Centrelink, Police, Childcare, the women's refuge, the regional refugee Health nurse, TAFE, Hunter New England Mental health group, Church groups, and so on. The networking is maintained by attending interagency meetings and through other interactions including participation in local events.

An example of Networking has been the provision of information sessions to target group clients through partnerships with a number of other agencies. The Tamworth project has facilitated number of information sessions with the Refugee health nurse, Hunter New England Mental health service, and the sexual health clinic. Topics have included nutrition, sexual health and transmissible diseases, health services, health system and other services in Australia

Emerging Sporting groups

One of the projects that the Tamworth SGP worker has been working on, has been the development of a multicultural Basketball team to include the Sudanese Refugees. A team has been formed and the Team is mid-way through the local competition calendar. Tamworth SGP worker has introduced children from Sudanese and CALD community to the Mid Night Basketball program run by Centrelink and the police. The Tamworth SGP worker is assisting the local Chinese in forming an indoor badminton club.

Other Issues

One major event faced by the project this year was to re-house the project in a more client friendly office. This took place in April with a move from the Police Citizens location to new premises in the grounds of the Tamworth West Primary School.



Links To Learning Community Grants Program

Chris Hudson

Funded by Minister for Education & Training

- administered by Department of Education & Training

Programme Overview

Links to Learning (L2L) is a creative and practical programme for young people who have, or are at risk of leaving school. The programme has two components – The At Risk project and The Early Leavers projects. Both have the same projected outcomes, that is, to assist young people to access, remain in, or return to education or training. The overall age demographic is 12 to 24 years of age and in the case of the Early Leavers project; it is 15 to 24 years of age. The other main identifying demographics are, that the young person is not working; in training and has signed out of school before finishing year 12. There is one caveat, and that is a person can start at the age of 14 years and 9 months, if they have a letter from the Headmaster stating that they are exiting school to participate in the programme.

NSS is running the Early Leavers project in Tamworth. The project was started by Michelle Steele in early-mid 2007 and was originally designated for CALD people. Michelle took time off on maternity leave and I was recruited as the locum in late October. Through my experience as a youth justice conference convenor, a plan-it-youth mentor, and my personal network, I had identified the overwhelming need for Links to Learning in the general community. This, coupled with the limited CALD young people who fill the criteria, prompted me to apply to the Department of Education and Training DET to change the population group to general.

Under the 2008 L2L guidelines, participant hours need to be between 100 and 500 hours. The funding agreement between NSS and DET is to provide the programme for 30 young people with an allocation of 7200 hours, which averages out at 240 hours per participant. These hours are split into: Group, Individual, and Individual Planning. Individual Work Experience is allowed for but is not necessarily part of the mainstream hours that go to make up the 240. The evaluative outcomes are measured by the number of participants and their respective hours that are completed. There are also employability skills and personal attributes that the different programme courses need to show that they impart to the participant directly or indirectly. These are:

Employability

- Communication Skills • Team work Skills • Problem Solving • Initiative and Enterprise Skills
- Planning and Organising Skills • Self management Skills • Learning Skills • Technology Skills.

Personal

- Loyalty • Commitment • Honesty and integrity • Enthusiasm • Reliability • Personal presentation • Common sense • Positive self esteem • Sense of humour • Balanced work and home life • Ability to deal with pressure • Motivation • Adaptability.

L2L in 2007

The programme commenced with Michelle Steele recruiting some young Sudanese people and some non CALD people from Gunnedah. The task of building networks of referrers and resources proved to be rather difficult. Michelle had four participants who reached various stages of their contracted hours with L2L.

Some of the difficulties Michelle encountered were, participants leaving to gain employment and leaving to travel back to the Sudan.

I started as the Locum Co-ordinator at the end of October. There were two potential participants at that time referred from the Pathways program at Job Link Plus. I secured another participant through the Home School Liaison Officer. The three went through a reduced hospitality course and a short computer course. The hospitality course was VET. accredited. These two courses only lasted 7 weeks. However, the three young people fulfilled the agreed hours and two went onto do year 10 at TAFE and the other went back to Peel High School to year 10 but was advanced to year 11. I have caught-up with the pair who went to TAFE recently and they are continuing their education and one is working as a casual at Coles Supermarket.

L2L in 2008

First Group

January and February are planning and organising months where I submit a programme plan and have it approved by DET. An Annual Report is also due for DET reporting procedures. To fulfil the expectation from DET with regard to participant hours, I decided to use a running intake as opposed to the three blocks of ten weeks which is based on school attendance. The programme commenced at the start of March with two participants, however, by the next week we had six. The participant demographic was 1 South African, 1 young person from Brain Injury Rehab at the Base Hospital, and the rest were non-indigenous Australians. The programme courses included song writing, guitar lessons, budgeting, hospitality, cooking, journaling, as well as ten-pin bowling, BBQ picnics and visits to the movies and the library. There was a couple of down times in the programme. During this time 1 participant left to obtain work, so he could go back to University and do a graphics degree; 1 left to do cert III in computers at TAFE; 1 left due to a grant to assist him in regaining his driving licence and other goals, and 1 left to take up employment. The others came back to the programme.

Second Group

There were seven starting in the second group with two restarting from the first group. In the main the second group came from referrals from high school. Most were exiting due to behaviour issues. Two were between the ages of 14 yrs 9 months and 15 years. These two young people had a covering letter stating that they were leaving school to do the L2L programme. Some started after I held a Pizza and information day at a local community centre. There were 3-5 others who indicated they would start but as yet have not done so. The demographics of the group are a mix of Indigenous and non-indigenous Australians and a Pilipino. The courses so far have included; jewellery, literacy and numeracy, mosaic work, computers, folder making and self awareness. Some of these courses need to be reviewed. Other courses I hope to introduce this year or next include screen printing, woodwork, video production and anger management. Some of the participants in this group are experiencing very disruptive issues and so 3 have left and 2 are hopefully returning.

Programme Development

Originally L2L had its office at the local PCYC. This was a situation that needed to change due to having a very small office and no dedicated venue use. We are at present in a disused schoolroom at a local public school. Whilst it is a step up from the PCYC we need to move on at the earliest opportunity. I have surveyed a number of possible locations and have a couple more yet to view. I am confident that we will find a suitable venue soon. I am building up infrastructure and resources to make the programme more accessible in the future. However, this does take time and with the conservative nature of Tamworth it needs persistence in establishing what the education sector has identified as being in need here. I have spoken to Rythe Duffy the Regional Director of Education for this area and she has expressed to me her desire to keep L2L operating in Tamworth. There are a lot of young people here L2L could benefit, as I indicated earlier it needs time as a new programme in this region to become established and recognised by the participants.



AGED CARE TEAM

Ms Sue (Slavica) Hristov
Aged Care Team Leader
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages

Ms Lupe Fonua
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages

Ms Tima 'Oto
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service

Ms Enza Di Stefano
Coordinator
Community Visitors Scheme

In the past year, there have been some changes to the structure of the Aged Care Team

Ms Christine Follett, the HMRS Coordinator resigned in May & Tima 'Oto was appointed as the new Coordinator (in addition to her role as a CACP Coordinator)

Our beloved Anne Dupree sadly passed away in July 2008

CENTRAL COAST AGED CARE TEAM

Sandra Wingrave
Team Leader - Central Coast
Senior Coordinator
Multicultural Social Support Service - Central Coast

Olivia Fuente
Coordinator
Multicultural Social Support Service - Central Coast

Ms Trudy Wahl
Administration Officer
Multicultural Social Support Service - Central Coast



Community Aged Care Packages

Sue Hristov, Tima 'Oto & Lupe Fonua
Funded by Commonwealth Department
of Health & Ageing

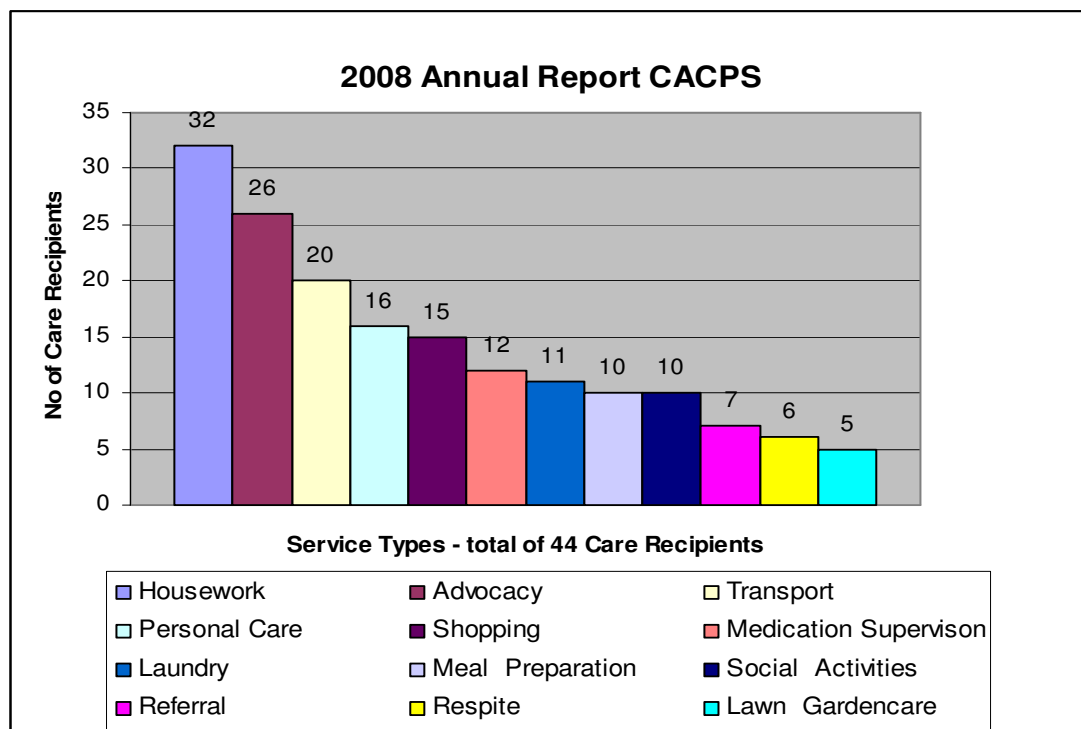
The Community Aged Care Project is in its eight year of successful operation, and continues to provide home based care and assistance to vulnerable, frail aged people with complex care needs.

We currently provide assistance with the tasks of daily living to 44 people from Culturally and Linguistically Diverse (CALD) backgrounds who wish to remain living at home as long as possible, in the Newcastle, Lake Macquarie, Maitland and Port Stephens local government areas

CARE RECIPIENT PROFILE

Care recipients come from a wide variety of cultural/ linguistic backgrounds: Ukrainian, Polish, Danish, German, Greek, Italian, Sri Lankan, Slovenian Italian, Macedonian, Chinese, Serbian, Japanese

- 11 male - 33 female - age range from 97 to 71 years old
- 21 living at home alone
- 23 have a live in carer
- 2 double packages- care required by both husband and wife
- 8 having a diagnosis of dementia



SERVICES PROVIDED

The Project currently provides 169 hrs of assistance per week- an average of 4 hrs per care recipient . Some people required only 1-2 hrs per week and others who do not have strong family/community support networks/ or have complex care needs required significantly more- one as high as 16 hrs per week and a few others between 8 and 13hrs/ week

This past year has seen a significant increase in the number of people (20% of the total) requiring higher level of care than CACP is designed to provide - about 5.5. hrs/week. Prudent financial management and a mix of both low & higher care clients has enabled us to offer the level of care required to make sure people are safe living at home until other options become available.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

The brokerage model of service delivery i.e. not employing care workers directly but contracting them from reputable agencies, has continued to provide the much needed flexibility and access to a wider pool of bilingual workers that our program requires.

Care recipient feedback indicates that our commitment and ability to provide a culturally and linguistically appropriate service is one of the main reasons we have had such a high rate of acceptance of packages from the CALD target group- in contrast to difficulties experienced by some mainstream providers.

CASE MANAGEMENT

While care workers assisted people with the tasks of daily living, the Co-ordinators spent a significant amount of time fulfilling their responsibilities of case managing the ongoing and often complex needs of care recipients. Some required minimal changes to their Care Plans while others required complex case management/almost daily or very regular monitoring due to their deteriorating health/dementia/ challenging behaviours/ carer stress/family conflict. Keeping the packages full has been challenging as the past year has seen a much higher than average turnover rate – 27 people have exited packages: eleven people who required high care have moved to residential/other care with the assistance of Coordinators and two have accepted an EACH (nursing home level assistance at home) from other service providers. Three other care recipients are awaiting an EACH.

QUALITY IMPROVEMENT

The CACP project has been involved in a systematic quality improvement process by conducting monthly Quality Audits focusing on Community Care Standards and strategies were put in place to address the issues identified.

All in all, another successful year for the CACP Project which continues to make a significant contribution to improving the quality of life for our target group. The positive feedback/appreciation expressed by care recipients/ their families makes the job of Coordinator very rewarding - while accommodating high care needs in a manner that fulfils our duty of care to ensure people are safe living at home, is a continuing challenge.

Many thanks to the NSS Board of Management, fellow colleagues / service providers, for your continued support and assistance.



Hunter Multicultural Respite Service

Christine Follett & Tima 'Oto

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare (DADHC) through Home & Community Care Program (HACC)

Hunter Multicultural Respite Service (HMRS) provides respite care for frail older people or people with dementia from non-English speaking backgrounds experiencing difficulty in attending Day Care Centres. The service provides a culturally appropriate worker to assist with care of clients at Day Care Centres to sustain the placement at Day Care and to provide the carers some respite.

Model of Service Provision

HMRS is staffed by one part-time coordinator for 3 days per week. Direct care services are provided on a brokerage model, i.e. care workers are contracted as needed from other existing providers such as Uniting Care, Home Care and Extra Care. The brokerage model has proven to be an efficient and effective model, as it enables the project to have a wider pool of workers to choose from and enables the service to better meet the cultural and linguistic needs of particular clients as well as covering all insurance issues.

Services provided

Throughout 2007 a total of 38 clients have had weekly services of between 2-8 hours per week, including transport for 8 clients. Two clients attend more than one Day Care Centre. A total of 6 new clients have commenced services in 2007 and 10 clients have either unfortunately died throughout the year or ceased service mainly due to placement into permanent residential care. All clients have been formally assessed initially and reviewed after 6 months of service. There are 3 clients on waiting list due to too many clients attending the Italian Centre. Homecare had put in a new policy – a ratio of 3 clients to one support worker only and currently six clients are attending weekly. In addition over 35 carers have been supported by direct service provision.

Day Care Centre	No of clients per Day Care as of 30/10/2008
Alkira Day Care	0
Allawah Day Care	3
Cardiff Multicultural Friendship Group	1
East Lake Macquarie Dementia Service	1
Greek Day Care Centre	5
Greek Holy Apostles Day Care Centre	3
Italian Day Care Centre	6
Macedonian Day Care Centre	2
Maitland Friendship Group	2
Polish Day Care Centre	6
Southlakes Day Care, Morisset	1
Wattle Grove Day Care Centre	9
TOTAL	38

Administration

- New agreements and risk assessments of Day care Centres were signed off throughout the year to follow up from DADHC action plan from review in 2006.
- MDS database was upgraded into the latest version V2.1.0 – we've had a few hiccups in the beginning – but all the data has been successfully transferred.
- MDS statistics compiled and sent to DADHC quarterly.

Multicultural Dementia Support Group

The service coordinates the monthly meeting of the group at the Northern Settlement Services Ltd premises on the third Wednesday of the month. Throughout the year we have had speakers and information sessions to assist and support carers of migrants with dementia from the following organisations: Commonwealth Care Respite Centre; Alzheimer's Australia NSW, Central Dementia Unit, Educare, "Beyond Maturity Blues" (Depression), NSW Seniors; Peer Education Support (Quality Use of Medications); Central Dementia Unit "How to Cope Living with Challenging Behaviour".

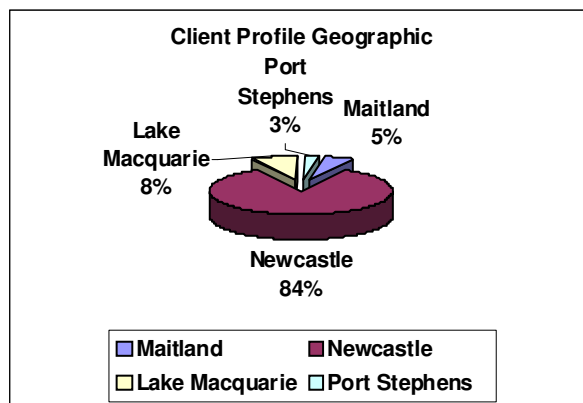
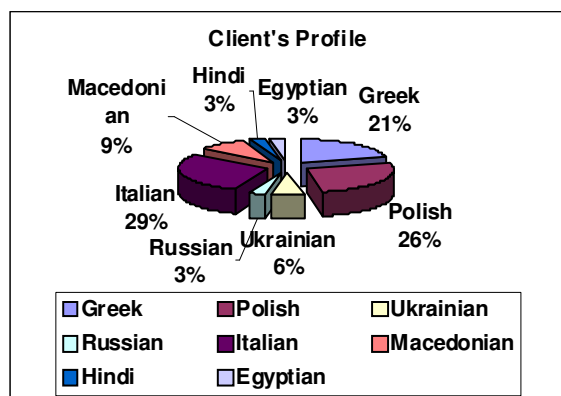
Training / conferences attended throughout the year include:

- Fire Training, Northern Settlement Services – 17 July 2007
- Interpreting Pilot Training, South West Sydney/Health Service - 24 July 2007
- Dementia Conference, Many Pathways, Many Windows – 19 & 20 June 2008

Meetings attended on a regular basis include:

- Quality and Team meetings, NSS Aged Care Services
- Hunter Ethnic Aged Services Network
- HACC services and Community Services Network quarterly meetings
- Dementia Interagency meetings
- Upper Hunter Interagency

<i>Client characteristics</i>						
<i>Gender</i>		<i>Age</i>			<i>Client condition</i>	
Male	Female	60-75	76-89	90+	Dementia	Frail Aged
12	26	3	28	7	20	18



I would like to thank the management and my colleagues at the Northern Settlement Services Ltd for their assistance and support, which has enabled the service to consolidate and build successfully throughout 2007-2008.



Community Visitors Scheme

Enza Di Stefano

Funded by Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing

Introduction:

The NSS Community Visitors Scheme (CVS) continues to provide socially isolated residents of aged care homes, who are from Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD), a better quality of life through one-on-one volunteer visitors, providing friendship and companionship. Matching Residents with Visitors who have similar cultural / language backgrounds is an essential element of the project.

***The CVS Program is celebrating fifteen years in 2008 –
a significant milestone for a highly effective, efficient and valued program***

Community Visitor Recruitment and Turnover:

Recruitment of volunteers is an on-going process - during the year a total of 18 volunteers were available. However, since my appointment 6 new active volunteers have been recruited with a further 3 currently undergoing orientation /Police Checks

Orientation Activities:

Orientation/ training/ support activities in the last twelve months focused on orientation for prospective visitors; a workshop on "Manual Handling for Volunteers" which reaffirmed the importance of looking after oneself and residents; organising 2 major outings: at the Christmas lunch outing each volunteer received a small gift from Santa and the Volunteer Week outing in May was a bus trip around Port Stephens with morning tea, a stroll along the marina, scenic viewing at Little Beach lighthouse and lunch. The visitors were most appreciative in being acknowledged for the invaluable contribution they make to the quality of life of the residents they visit.

Information and Promotion Activities:

Letters of introduction and mail outs to residential facilities to raise awareness of what NSS CVS can offer residents and seeking referrals for CALD residents who might benefit from a visitor have proved successful with 8 requests received of which 7 have currently been met.

The most successful promotion activities have proven to be the extensive and longstanding contacts/good working relationships with local ethnic communities/ organisations and networks servicing a similar target group. These will remain the main focus of future promotion activities with presentations at the many community groups scheduled for the new year. Networking with other CVS auspices in the region continues with four referrals leading to the recruitment of two new visitors.

A publicity campaign with our local community radio station which broadcasts in a dozen different languages took place in June; at this stage it is too early to ascertain the benefits of the advertising.

Levels of metropolitan, rural and remote activity.

The NSS Community Visitor Scheme covers the 4 Lower Hunter LGA's of Newcastle, Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens and Maitland, some having a rural/ metropolitan interface. To date, we have not been able to respond to occasional requests from Upper Hunter as the majority of available Visitors live in the more Metropolitan areas and are not able/ willing to travel the considerable distances involved in such a geographically dispersed area. Continuing efforts will be made to address the needs of the Upper Hunter depending on the availability of Visitors.

Number of Nursing homes visited by LGA 2007-2008

LGA	Nursing homes currently visited	Currently stopped visitation	Total of nursing homes visited
Newcastle	8		8
Lake Macquarie	5	2	7
Port Stephens	3		3
Maitland	1	1	2
Total	17	3	20

- *Cessation of visitor activity to Nursing Homes was due to two residents passing away and one Visitor passing away and one visitor resigning.*
- *20 Nursing Homes- with a total of 926 visits to 39 residents*
- *covering a distance of 17,000 kilometres.*

Benefits of the Scheme:

Community Visitors play an integral role in easing the social/ cultural isolation experienced by many residents who may not have family close by and whose extended support networks were left behind when they migrated. The scheme also provides an opportunity for residents to maintain a link to the community through sharing of news/ current activities in the community. One of the major achievements of the Scheme is its continuing ability to provide support to people from a wide range of backgrounds despite the demographic reality of an ageing population – most of the current Visitors are drawn from communities which settled here post World War 11. This diminishing pool of visitors has necessitated adopting a useful and necessary strategy of a number of visitors seeing more than one resident in the same facility and often in different facilities. Adopting this strategy has resulted in the program being able to provide support to a larger number of residents that would otherwise miss out.

Identified Difficulties:

The main difficulties remain the recruitment of suitable visitors from the diminishing ethnic population group and the long distances needing to be travelled because of the geographically dispersed target group. Visiting people of advanced age and serious health issues especially dementia, can have a considerable emotional toll on visitors and this necessitates ongoing counselling and support from the Co-ordinator.

Satisfaction with the Service Provided:

The feedback the Program continues to receive from residents as well as staff of residential facilities shows that the service provided is welcomed and much appreciated. There is no doubt that the residents from culturally and linguistically diverse backgrounds would experience a greater degree of social isolation without the support and friendship provided by the Visitors.



Multicultural Social Support Service Central Coast

Sandra Wingrave, Olivia Fuente & Trudy Wahl

Funded by the Department of Ageing, Disability & Home Care (DADHC)

– Home & Community Care (HACC) Program

The Multicultural Social Support Service (MSSS) supports CALD people in Wyong & Gosford LGAs who are: frail aged, younger people with a disability, and carers.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

Volunteers provide social support to clients and carers which includes: home visits, telephone calls, taking clients: shopping, banking, to medical appointments etc and supporting clients to attend outings and events, including organised client activity days.

ADMINISTRATION

The following administration tasks have been undertaken throughout the year.

- Monthly media releases inform the community about MSSS, and are also for the purpose of recruiting new Volunteers. 64 Volunteer application kits were sent out as a result of the advertising. 44% of Volunteer applicants found out about the service through advertising in local commercial newspapers and this continues to be the most successful means of attracting new Volunteers.
- Compilation and Distribution of the Volunteer Newsletter.
- Relevant OH&S assessments and processes were carried out as scheduled.
- Processing of Volunteer reimbursements, Client service fees and petty cash balancing.
- Successful move to new premises at Tuggerah Lakes Community Centre, Bateau Bay was achieved in May. The location of our office is now much more central to the whole of the Central Coast.
- Office Manager Sharlene Huber resigned in May.
- Trudy Wahl was appointed Administration Support Officer in June, and her three month trial period, and review was successfully completed.

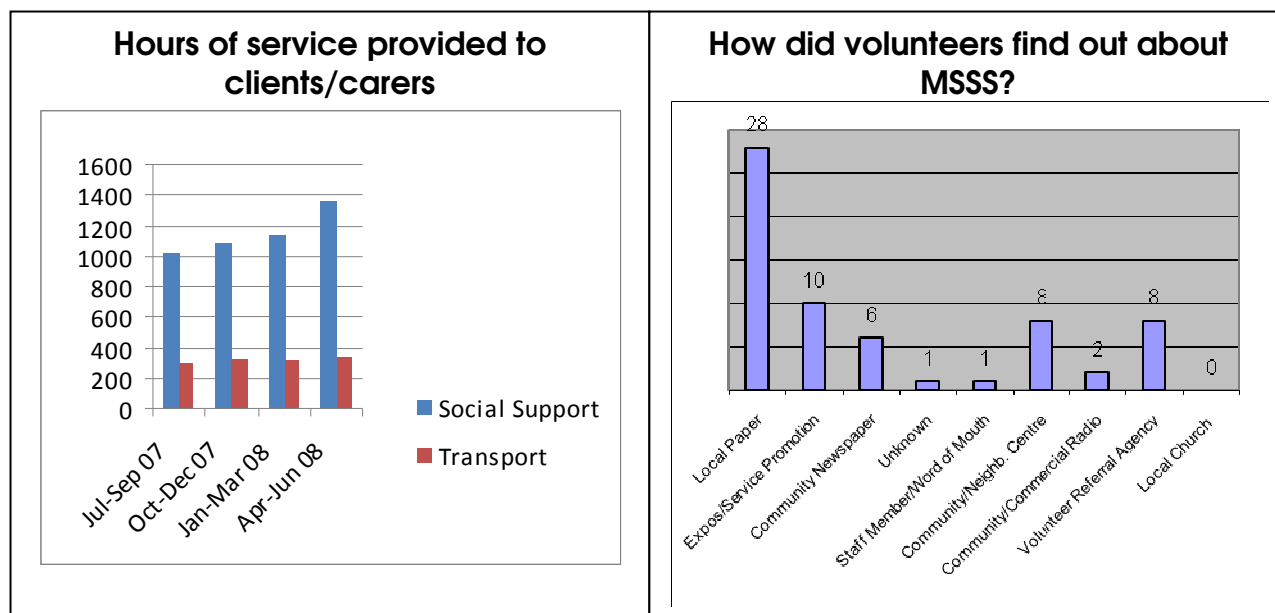
VOLUNTEERS

- To date, the service has 38 registered Volunteers, 32 of whom are actively involved with clients, and of which, 47% speak languages other than English
- Four Training days and Supervision & Support Meetings have been held throughout the year. Training has included: Cross Cultural Awareness, Manual Handling, Cultural Awareness, and Infection Control. Volunteers have also attended training provided by HACC, including First Aid, Introduction to Challenging Behaviour, and Boundaries.
- Our volunteers are always willing to assist with extra activities, including helping out at Service promotions, and client group social days.
- We expressed our appreciation to our volunteers with a Christmas Lunch in November, and also during National Volunteer Week in May, with a special lunch and special presentations.

CLIENTS/CARERS

- MSSS provides service to 78 clients and carers. We continue to receive referrals for clients from ACAT, Community Nursing, local hospitals, other community services, word of mouth, and from our advertising and promotions.
- During this year, MSSS assisted a local Italian group by facilitating a fortnightly social day in the north of the Central Coast. However, after four months of operation, the group ceased, due to lack of numbers.

- In our new premises, we have access to a large meeting room, so we have been conducting regular, monthly social days for our clients from both Wyong and Gosford areas. Our volunteers provide transport, and assist with the activities.
- Nationalities represented within our Client/Carer service include Chinese, Polish, Maltese, Singaporean, Filipino, Spanish, Greek, Italian, Austrian, German, Croatian, Finnish, Hungarian, Serbian, Dutch, Russian, Fijian, Egyptian, Chilean, Vietnamese, Slovakian, and Uruguayan.



PROMOTION

During 2007 – 2008, MSSS was involved in various activities which allowed for promoting the service:-

- * Harmony Day events
- * Gosford Public Hospital
- * Connecting Women, C.C.
- * C.C. Community radio
- * Ageing 2030 Community Consultation
- * C.C. Private Hospitals
- * Impact of Ageing for older people from CALD backgrounds
- * Carers' Services Expo.
- * Seniors' Week
- * Central Coast TAFE - Welfare
- * ET Welfare Students
- * Ourimbah University
- * Multicultural Services & Info. Expo.

We have continued to advertise: in the local media; The Senior newspaper; Community Newsletters; at Neighbourhood Centres, etc; by continuous distribution of service brochures; and by networking with other community services.



AFRICAN TEAM

Mr Michael Adderley
Community Projects Officer
African Team Leader

Mr Simon Majur Pabek
Sudanese & African Communities Support Project (SGP)

Mr Marial Fieg
African Youth Project

Mr Mohamed Kamara
African Family Support Project

Ms Zenaida Edmunds
African Family Support Project

Mr Zachary Karithi
African Family Support Project

Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye
African Family Support Project

Mr Michael Freund
Volunteers Coordinator



Community Projects Officer
African Team Leader
Michael Adderley

Overview

The projects that exist within the African Team are funded by a range of government departments and support the various African refugee communities in the Newcastle and Hunter regions. Our current clients come from Sudan, Liberia, Burundi, Sierra Leone, Rwanda, the Democratic Republic of Congo and Mauritania who require assistance with a wide range of issues including settlement advice, accommodation, finances, family relationships, education, employment as well as general welfare support.

The workload of the African team members has remained constant over the last 12 months despite the reduction in the number of new African refugee families settling in this region. A number of improvements to processes have increased our ability to assist members of the African community, including a more thorough hand-over procedure of clients from the IHSS (Integrated Humanitarian Support Strategy) to Northern Settlement Services' Settlement Grants Programs.

In addition to my role as African Team Leader, I oversaw a number of new projects during this financial year. These were as follows:

Safe Arrival, Safe Families

Funded by Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs (FaHCSIA) through the *Stronger Families & Communities Strategies* program.

This project commenced in September 2007 and will run until 30th June 2009. The objective of this project is to improve family relationships within African refugee families through a number of activities. These include:

- Conducting culturally appropriate parenting information sessions for existing and newly arrived African refugee families
- Train and inform community leaders and community workers to better equip them with parenting information when assisting members of their community
- Assist African refugee youths to deals with family relationships

Amer Manyuon (Sudanese) and **Joselyne Ntahomvukiye** (Burundi) are employed part time to support the respective communities' women's groups who meet at Penola House. The project has been useful in strengthening parenting and relationships skills, through formal information sessions and workshops (in partnership with Relationships Australia and Newcastle Family Support Services) and the tireless help of NSS volunteers.

Continued over page...

African Community Radio Program

Funded by Community Development Support Expenditure program

In July 2007 the **African Community Radio Program** was established through funding from Clubs NSW's Community Development Support Expenditure program. The aim of this project was to establish a radio program that informed the members of Newcastle's African refugee community about important settlement information in an entertaining radio program format. The major language groups catered for in this program were Arabic & Dinka (Sudanese), Swahili (Burundi, Rwandan & Congolese) and Creole (Liberia & Sierra Leone).

The first program aired on 2NURFM (103.7FM) on the 21st of October 2007. The program aired each Sunday night between 10pm – 11pm. Due to the 4 language groups, each language program consisted of ½ hour segment aired fortnightly. The radio programs were supported by **Biko Syong'oh** who developed the weekly script and recorded each program with the volunteer presenters from the various African communities. The use of volunteers from the African communities as presenters did provide some challenges, and led to some anxious moments. It is obvious that even though members of the community liked the concept of having their own radio program and believed there was a need for it, the success of a community radio program rests on the ongoing commitment of community people themselves who are prepared to sacrifice their time. . That said, the project is still a very useful method of connecting and communicating with the refugee communities and should be supported in the longer term.

Casework

In my role as African Team leader I also take on a number of complex cases to support the African community workers at NSS.

The following table illustrates the major issues I have been involved in- housing and accommodation (25%), legal issues (14%), education & training (10%) and family issues (9%). Key issues facing the refugee community remain- suitable, affordable and available housing, employment opportunities and education. These will continue to be long-term issues and take considerable time to resolve for each client facing these problems.

Problems / Issues	Number of contacts	Problems / Issues	Number of contacts
Bills issues	12	Legal issues	53
Child Protection	3	Mental health	5
Education and training issues	37	Neighbourhood disputes	7
Employment issues	19	Parenting issues	4
Family issues	33	Police	6
Filling in forms	25	Settlement information	2
Finance	23	Sporting assistance	8
Health issues	18	Transport issues	7
Housing and accommodation	94	Youth issues	24
Immigration and proposing relatives	1	Learning English	2
Total			383

Throughout the year I have represented NSS on a number of committees including the Hunter Cooperative Legal Service Delivery workgroup, Hunter Violence Against Women Committee, the Family Relationship Centre Community Reference Group and the White Ribbon Day planning committee.



Sudanese & African Communities Support Project (SGP)

Simon Majur Pabek

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grants Program

This project is in its fifth year period of offering information referral and casework to African refugees, and working with mainstream providers in the Newcastle and Lower Hunter Region. In the last twelve months, more than **339** clients were registered to Online Settlement Client Activity Reports (OSCAR), and **700** occasions of services provided either by phone or face to face.

While most of these services were delivered in the Newcastle area, a weekly outreach session was held at Metford TAFE in order to make this service more accessible for the target group, predominantly Sudanese attending AMEP classes.

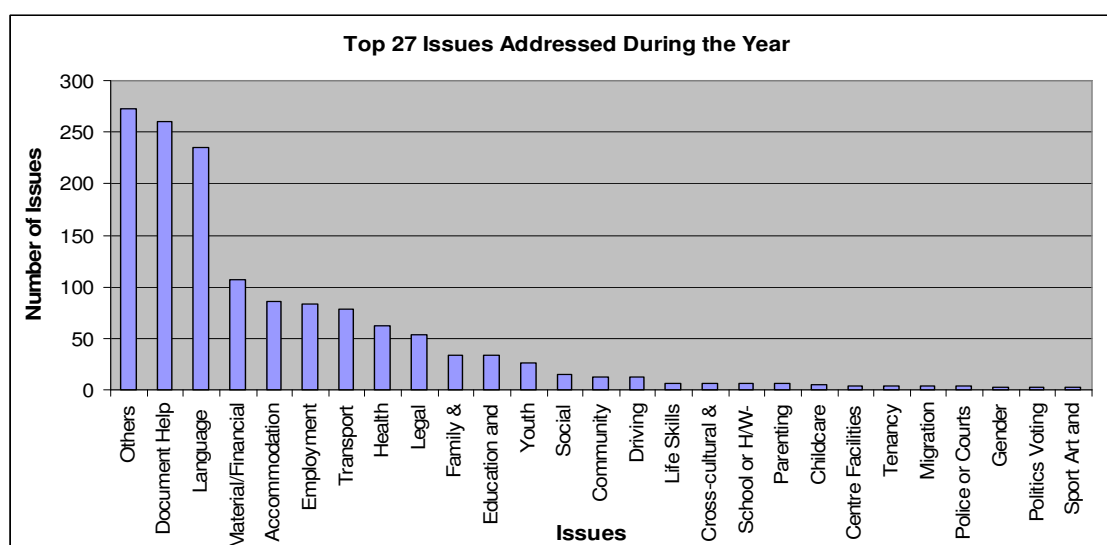


Figure 1

Figure 1 shows the nature of the services and the top 27 issues addressed during the past year for this project. Document help (260), language help (235), Material/Financial assistance (107), and accommodation assistance (86) were the most significant.

Group Work

23 group sessions have been provided for target communities within the 600-700 African refugees residing in the Newcastle and Lower Hunter Region.

Figure 2 shows the breakdown of sessions: Community Development (4); African Cultural Awareness (4); Settlement Information (3); Health (3); Youth and Education Issues (3); Employment (3); Housing and Accommodation (2). The majority of sessions were well attended by service providers, government agencies and newly-arrived refugees.

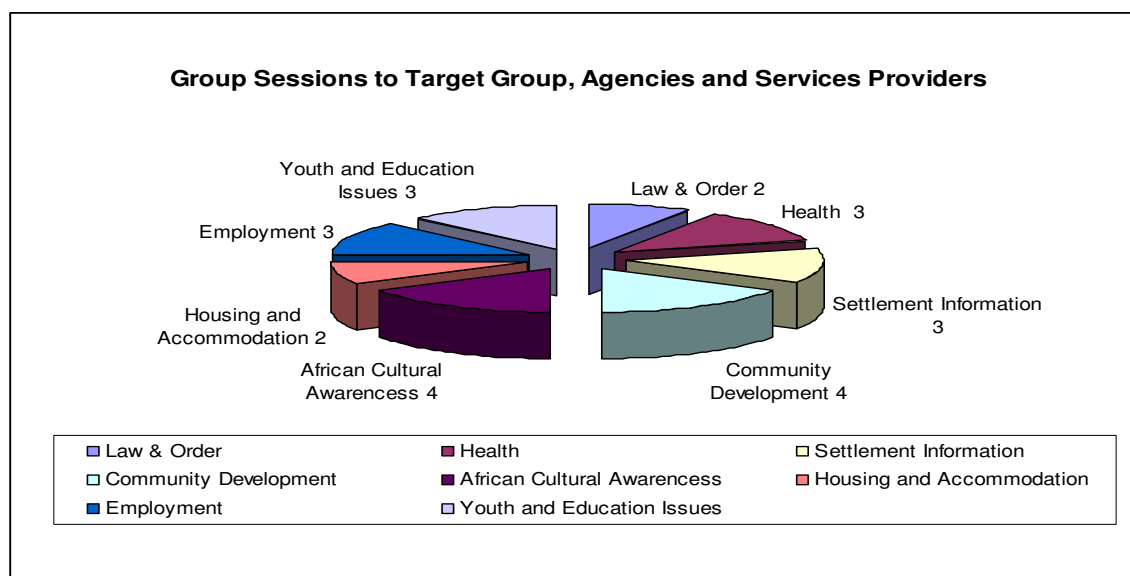


Figure 2

Other Work - Community Development

Presentations were made at several community sessions organised by NSS in the course of the year. The first session was the African Cultural Forum, targeting community workers funded by DOCS; approximately 72 in attendance. The second session was at Newcastle TAFE for AMEP teachers, and the third session was at NSS for all NSS workers, and was delivered by the AMES officer.

The project worked collaboratively with all NSS projects and volunteers in the delivery of a quality support service to the target group, and in particular those who were exited from the IHSS.

In addition, the African SGP worker attended **four** sessions organised by other agencies for newly-arrived refugees, including the Sudanese, Liberian and Burundian communities and the Hunter African Communities Council.

Input and support was provided to the Newcastle Liberian community on "Liberian Opening Day" in June 2008, for an inter city Soccer 'friendly,' which included boys' and girls' teams. The tournament concluded with a very successful social event.



African Youth Project

Marial Fieg

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The aim of the project is to identify and address the issues of young people of African background aged from 12-24 years living in Newcastle with outreach to Lake Macquarie and Maitland. The position aims to increase youth participation in existing services and to develop responses to cover gaps in youth services provision, especially to small and emerging communities.

The main work of the project is to provide support, information, referral, casework, service planning and development and capacity building to assist African young people in their settlement. The project also participates in local and regional youth and community networks.

Recreational Activities

I have developed and supported a range of sporting and recreational activities for young Africans during 2007-2008, which have been a great way of encouraging young people to participate in community activities, assisting with their integration into Australian life, improving self-confidence and developing life skills. These include:

- Weekly activities at Newcastle Police & Citizen's Youth Club (PCYC), eg. gymnasium, boxing, weightlifting, etc and also the PCYC basketball team.
- Weekly games at Newcastle Basketball Association for African Lions team.
- Weekly activities at Hamilton South Community Centre (run by Samaritans Foundation), eg. social activities, table-tennis, pool table, video games, etc.
- African soccer teams (Flying Eagles and Kangaroos) participating in friendly matches against mainstream teams.
- Several camping excursions in partnership with STARTTS Recreation Officer.
- Youth dancing groups: West African and Sudanese. Also in partnership with Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre (MNC) youth worker.
- School holiday Youth Activity Day at PCYC in partnership with MNC & STARTTS workers.

Youth Employment

Unemployment is a huge issue for all African communities and especially for young African people in the Hunter region, resulting in social and economic disadvantage. This project is working hard with the other African projects at Northern Settlement Services to raise awareness and knowledge of employment, vocational and educational needs of refugee African young people, running many sessions in different areas, eg. schools, TAFE, Work Directions/Job Find, Salvation Army and various networks.

Education & Training

Large numbers of young Africans are enrolled in various schools, high schools and primary schools and TAFEs around Newcastle and Hunter Region, and since its inception the project has been working with schools and parents for the purpose of integrating the newly arrived young people into the mainstream community. I have attended regular meetings in schools with staff and parents, and ran sessions about cultural awareness and study/employment pathway options.

For one half day per week, the project has outreached to schools with large numbers of African students, eg. Lambton High, San Clemente High (Mayfield), Callaghan College (Jesmond). These visits aim to mentor and build confidence in African students, and to break down communication barriers between these students, their parents and school staff. The sessions have also provided opportunities for African students to meet with Police to discuss their concerns.

Skill Development

I completed my Community Worker (Certificate IV) course at TAFE.

I also attended the three day Rural SGP & CSSS workers conference in May, which provided training for SGP & CSSS workers working in regional and rural NSW.

Table 1: African Youth Project Clients in the Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and Maitland area, during the reporting period.

Sudanese	65%
Liberian	20%
Sierra Leone	5%
Burundian	5%
Congolese	5%

Table 1 indicates the numbers of young people that the project has worked with from all African communities in the Newcastle and Hunter Regions. Sudanese young people were the largest group with 65% of all clients being Sudanese. This number was below last year's 75% figure, due in part to the success of NSS youth programs, as well as some client relocation away from the area. The good relationship this project has with schools and community services provides relatively easy access to the client group.

In conclusion, this project has been able to support young African refugees in a range of activities, as well as focus on and support other agencies in the direct need of African young people. It has also assisted with the development of strategies to support African youths and to encourage these youths to support themselves.



African Family Support Project (Families First)

Mohamed Kamara, Zenaïda Edmunds,
Zachary Ekandi, Joselyne Ntamomvukiye,
Funded by Department of Community Services

The aim of this project is to assist African refugee families with children aged 0 to 5 years, from the key refugee communities: Liberian, Sierra Leonean, Burundian, Congolese, Rwandan, as well as Sudanese, to access services, such as health, finance, training, education and cultural practices, and to develop parenting skills, confidence and self-esteem. Because of the diverse range of these communities, the project was shared among the following four Family Support Workers.

Mohamed Kamara

2007-2008 was a very challenging year, both as Family Support Worker and member of the African community. My case load for the year included families from: West Africa (Liberia, Sierra Leone) (**11**), Sudan (**2**), Burundi (**1**), and Dem. Rep. Congo (**1**). **Four** families were assisted throughout the year.

Over **181** home visits were made and family members assisted to access services, including: Centrelink, health, education, training, housing, employment. Referrals were also made for families wanting to propose spouses and relatives for immigration. The number of face-to-face and telephone contacts made for each service / issue is shown in the table below.

Services / Issues	Face To Face	Telephone
Employment	71	77
Education and Training	82	83
Youth	105	112
Health	108	108
Accommodation	48	81
Settlement information	41	50
Legal issues	18	53
Childcare	63	101
Transport and driving	70	87
Interpreting	34	16
Form Filling & Assistance	47	38
Trans-cultural information	38	90
Law and Order / Police	7	13
Referrals & other information	76	200
Totals	808	1109

The past year saw significant needs arise in our community, especially from parents, including many young parents, with children aged 0 to 5 years. Activities to assist these families were organised, such as the West African Mothers group, which aimed to develop more self-confident parents with improved parenting skills. The creation of the West African Youth Cultural dancing group improved the self-confidence and self-expression of West African Youth, allowing for better integration with the wider youth community. The African Radio Program on 2NUR-FM was another community activity to which I contributed, enabling information to be passed onto the African communities across the Hunter region.

I attended several Inter-Agency meetings, a Youth Mental Health conference and the Refugee Experience workshop. I also attended training courses on: working with men and family violence; case management; identifying and responding to risk of harm; and child protection dynamics (by SAAP/DOCS). These courses have greatly increased my ability and knowledge in social and community services work, especially in terms of policies, regulations and procedures.

Zenaida Edmunds

I supported & visited 10 families and 16 children under 5 years old, assisting with many activities, including:

- Provided play and learning experiences to the children such as: water/sand play, puzzles, music and movement, painting, pasting and storytelling.
- Modelled positive responses to children's tantrum and demanding behaviour by listening and acknowledging their needs.
- Modelled positive ways of handling children's behaviour, especially if it involves children's safety.
- Provided parents with information and advice with regards to different children's services available.
- Provided parents with information about the importance of children's supervision, safety issues inside and outside of the house, and the use of child restraint seats when taking children in cars.
- Organised a series of workshops addressing house cleaning, such as: kitchen, bathroom, and floors.
- Organised a family picnic during ANZAC weekend to create awareness about the significance of ANZAC amongst Australians.
- Organised a Mother's Day lunch, to acknowledge and recognise the importance of mothers in the family and explained to African mothers why Australians celebrate Mother's Day.
- Provided parents with information about healthy cooking and demonstrated cooking activities using recipes from the "Healthy Cooking on a Budget Cookbook".

Zach Ekandi & Joselyne Ntahomvukiye

The case load for the year included 16 families (60 people) from the Burundian, Congolese and Rwandan Communities. The main activities and support offered for these communities were aimed at enhancing those approaches geared towards family support, education, integration, health and skills development both inside and outside of the home environments. These approaches drew upon and further built social capital, self-reliance and empowerment of African communities, assisting smoother transition into successful settling, thus reducing their dependency and increasing their positive involvement in society.

African Family Support Workers were involved in the development and support of a wide range of organised activities, including:

- NAALA Saturday English and Conversation classes. Attendance rates were impressive, and this surely has had some positive outcomes for English literacy and homework.
- Red Cross Tracing Service session. Information was provided on this service and how they could help find/trace family members and relatives.
- Cleaning workshops for women over three days. This covered cleaning of houses, cookware, whitegoods and general home cleanliness.
- Parenting course for women, facilitated by Relationships Australia, providing parenting information to newly arrived families..
- Health Session facilitated by Family Planning Staff.

... Continued over page

- Women's Sewing Classes conducted at Penola House with the help of NSS volunteers who teach the women how to use sewing machines for making dresses, children's clothes, quilts, cushions, pillows, etc.
- Women's Cooking Classes. Facilitated by the Family Support Workers, covered healthy eating, cooking different foods, children's school lunches, preserving cooked food at home, and checking food health information.
- Visits to homes of young parents and families with children, by Family Support Workers. Support given included: childcare issues, doctor appointments, accommodation, interpreting and filling in forms.
- Gender Role Forum for African Men. Facilitated by social worker from Mayfield Maycare, providing information about roles men can play in Australia to support their partners and children.
- Fishing Talk, by a Fisheries staff member, provided information about the fishing licences, safety, which fish are/are not legal to catch, etc.

There were also a considerable number of issues throughout the year which directly or indirectly impacted on our work. Some of these included:

- **Employment** - Due to limited employment opportunities, some families relocated, or are considering relocation to other states.
- **Accommodation** - Lack of affordable accommodation around Newcastle area was another big problem for most of the families, forcing a small number of families to relocate to Perth and Adelaide for cheaper accommodation.
- **Transport** – poor public transport is a significant issue, and the increase in the number of practice driving hours required (120) by RTA has made it almost impossible for most people to get licences.

This project has now concluded, because of funding limitations.



Volunteers Coordinator
Michael Freund

The purpose of this part-time position (2.5 days/week), funded by NSS, is to recruit and co-ordinate the activities of volunteers working with refugee families. I took over this role from Paul Sidebottom on 17 September 2007. This report covers the period from that date to 30 June 2008. The year's activities can be summarised under the following headings:

Recruitment:

Continual recruitment of new volunteers was critical to the success of our existing volunteer-client programs. It was necessary to replenish some programs, eg. Homework Centre, with fresh people to replace the inactive or withdrawn volunteers. In other programs, such as Sewing Groups, extra volunteers made it possible to expand activities.

Volunteer recruitment was boosted by partnering with the School of Education (University of Newcastle), whose students volunteered in our Homework Centre & Volunteers In Schools Programs. Numbers were also increased by utilising the University Careers Office, by referrals from the Hunter Volunteer Centre, by radio & newspaper articles about Penola House, and via my NSS Volunteers website.

Each new volunteer completed & signed: 1) Volunteer Agreement; 2) Volunteer Information, 3) Prohibited Persons Employment Declaration, and 4) had a NSW Police Check done.

Programs:

The table below shows the main volunteer activities for the year, and the number of volunteers who participated in each program during the reporting period:

Program	# Vols.	Volunteer Activities
Homework Centre	18	Volunteers assisted students with their homework, at Hamilton Public School, one afternoon per week. Students ranged from primary school to Year 11.
In-Home Tutoring	23	Volunteers provided homework/study support for students at the family home. Students ranged from primary & secondary school to TAFE & University level.
Volunteers in Schools Program (VISP)	21	Volunteers provided in-class support for students, one-on-one at a range of primary & secondary public schools. DET Refugee Support Officer, Renata Ninevski ran several VISP training sessions for the volunteers, and also set up their school placements.
Penola House: Sewing Groups	18	Volunteers instructed African women how to setup & cut out material patterns for dresses, etc., then how to use the sewing machines. Sufficient volunteers were provided to increase the sewing groups from one day to four days per week: Mon-Thu 10am-2pm at Penola House.
Penola House: Reception, Childminding, etc.	16	Volunteers undertook reception & office duties, supervision of African children, gardening work, etc. Mon-Thu 10am-2pm at Penola House.

General Family Support	37	Volunteers assisted families with shopping, budgeting, homecare, adult English language support, social support and other issues.
Transport: Shopping, Sporting, Appointments, etc.	12	Volunteers provided a range of transport services to: shopping centres, sporting functions, medical/legal appointments, health & dental clinics, etc.
Driving Supervision	9	Volunteers supervised 'L' plate drivers, assisting them to log the hours necessary to apply for 'P' licence. Note: It was very difficult to find volunteers willing to do driving supervision. I will need to find a better way to fill the growing demand for assistance with this activity.
Other: General, Community Work, One-offs, etc.	11	Volunteers performed a range of activities including setting up and maintaining computers, psychological counselling, mentoring youths, household repairs, gardening, repairing bicycles, teaching music, etc.
Unsure if active *	23	I suspect these volunteers became inactive/ withdrawn.

* As at 30 June 2008, our volunteer database showed that about **188** volunteers were actively working in client programs, or awaiting placement. A comprehensive audit of all volunteers' activities is to be conducted later in 2008 to determine more accurate numbers.

Homework Centre:

The purpose of the Homework Centre is to provide free homework tutoring for children from refugee families, who are unable to get the assistance in their home. The Centre commenced at Hamilton Public School, one day per week from 4:00 to 5:30pm. In January 2008, we were able to appoint a co-ordinator (courtesy of some funding from Uniting Care) which greatly improved the Centre's functioning, and volunteer numbers were boosted by the University Education student recruitment. Typically, regular attendances for 2008 increased by 50% (on 2007 figures), to 12-15 children and 10-12 volunteers. Plans are being made to open additional Homework Centres in 2009, possibly at San Clemente HS, Mayfield, which will provide the service within the Catholic & high school systems. We hope to do this with funding just received from the CDSE (NSW Clubs).

Community Refugee Support (CRS) Group:

We have continued our collaboration with the Community Refugee Support (CRS) Group, supporting their various social and awareness raising activities. Our thanks to Ron Davis (Coordinator, CRS) for his great commitment to refugee welfare.

NSS Volunteers Website:

This website was set up last year and continues to be a very useful contact and recruitment point, accessible from the NSS main website page, by clicking on "Volunteers".

Conclusion:

I have immensely enjoyed my first year with NSS in the Volunteers Co-ordinator role, and sincerely thank Michael Adderley and his African Team workers, who have supported me throughout. Also, a big thanks to our fantastic office staff, especially, Silvia & Helen, who have happily provided much hands-on labour for my volunteer mail-outs and ID badges. I look forward to the year ahead, working with our current & future group of dedicated volunteers, in supporting our refugee clients.



WELFARE TEAM

Ms Petrona Kelly
Welfare Team Leader
Filipino Social Worker

Ms Elena Ferguson
Russian Welfare Project

Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Thai Welfare Project

Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Project
(Samoan)

Ms Sara Stankovic / Ms Lydia Manusiu
Pacific Islander Welfare Project
(Tongan)

Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Migrant & Refugee Women's Support Project

Ms Miza Torlakovic
Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)



Filipino Welfare Project

Petrona Kelly

Funded by Department of Community Services

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Filipino people, mainly women and children who are experiencing physical and psychological crisis and hardship through domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and isolation, immigration issues and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

Key Service Specification of this project includes:

1. Provision of information, options and referrals to clients
2. Provision of intervention/group work to individuals and families
3. Provision of support and/or practical support /physical assistance to clients
4. Advocate access to services for individuals and families
5. Provision of community information or education to raise awareness, issues, services and activities
6. Build & maintain community networks/service system
7. Plan, develop & support new & existing services to meet the community's needs
8. Plan, develop & support community building events

The worker is available at NSS four days during the week.

This report covers the financial year 1st July 2007 to June 2008.

This year I have provided approximately 2,206 instances of services to clients. Their issues are inter-related in many cases and on many occasions, a client presented a number of needs/problems. As can be seen from the statistics, client settlement information forms a significant part of my work; immigration, financial, domestic violence, housing, legal and health matters predominate as problem areas.

Issues/Problems Presented by Clients:

Immigration & Citizenship	172	Income Support & Finances	158
Domestic Violence	143	Housing & Accommodation	130
Legal Matters	111	Health	108
Family Problems	100	Youth Problems	87
Education	80	Employment	78
Mental Health	65	Aged Care	51
Childcare	49	Overseas Qualification	43
Police	30	Learning English	23
Settlement Information	400	Other	378

Other includes social/emotional problems, separation & divorce, death & bereavement, social isolation, gambling problem, neighbourhood disputes, income tax returns, harassment & discrimination, language difficulties, transport difficulties, forms filling, court support, access to belongings, lost passports, compensation, funeral arrangement, passport renewals, translation of documents, JP signatures, referee, problem with real estates, traffic infringements, supporting letters, cultural information, etc. Presently, we also have Filipino women including children on two-year temporary visas who have escaped domestic violence and are awaiting immigration decision. One has three young children and came from a Sydney Women's & Children's Refuge to another refuge in Newcastle.

Services Provided:

Counselling	308	Advocacy	183
Referrals	272	Document Translations	127
Letter of Support.	25	Interpreting.	112
JP Signatures.	177	Forms Filling	90
General Information	400	Consultancy	109
Home/Hospital Visits	65	General Support	202
Court Support	37	Other	99

Community Development:

In partnership with other service providers and other agencies I have organised the following for the community:

- Alternative Medicine, Eye Problem & Blood Pressure (New England & Hunter Area Multicultural Health)
- Consumer Rights, Home Building & Renovation & Repairs, Buying Goods & Services, Scams that Affect Consumers, Resolving Complaints, Buying & Selling Cars (Department of Fair Trading)
- Changes to Family Assistance: Shared Care of Children (Child Support Agency)
- Age Pension Policy on Taking Pension Overseas Re: Working Life Residence & Working Age Residence (Centrelink)
- Dual Citizenship Information Session in Newcastle (Philippine Consulate Sydney)
- Dual Citizenship mass Oath-taking Ceremony in Newcastle (Philippine Consulate Sydney)

Trainings:

During the year I have maintained networking with peers and colleagues and other service providers to further develop skills and enhance information level to better serve the needs of the community by attending trainings, workshops, seminars, etc. such as:

- Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare (DADHC)
- Fire Safety Prevention Training
- Case Management: An Introduction
- Making Sense of Financial Statements
- Working with People with Mental Illness
- Case Management of Clients with Complex Needs
- Legal Seminar on Domestic Violence & Victims of Crime Compensation
- Good Practice Guidelines Workshops
- Demystifying Mental Illness Seminar
- White Ribbon Breakfast
- EduCare Support Services NSW Health
- Family Strength Perspective Workshop
- NSW Ombudsman Workshop
- Advocacy, Complaints Handling Workshop
- Identifying & Responding to Risk of Harm of Children
- Grant Writing Workshop
- Advanced Workshop for Domestic Violence Counselling

Other Activities:

This year I reconvened the monthly NSS Caseworkers Meeting and throughout the year I had organised and invited speakers relevant to our workers' needs. It is a pleasure leading the Welfare Team who create such a wonderful working environment.

Finally, I have had a hectic year but a satisfying one. Warm thanks to my colleagues for their support and encouragement. Likewise, to the NSS Board of Management for their most valued support of the Filipino Welfare Project.



Russian Welfare Project

Elena Ferguson

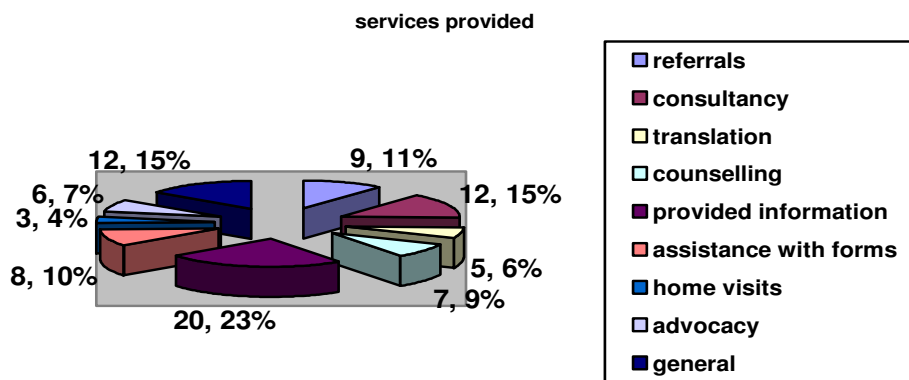
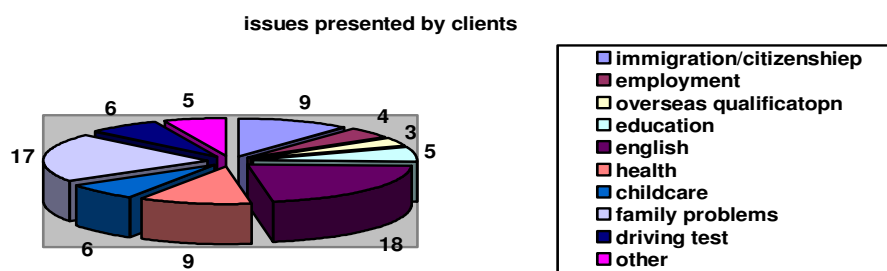
Funded by Department of Community Services

The Russian Family Welfare project is funded by Department of Community services and by the NSW Department of Community Services.

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Russian speaking people, mainly women and children who are experiencing immigration issues, social isolation, language problems, difficulties in finding a job and therefore stress and frustration which creates barriers in adjusting to this new country

This report covers the period from 01.07.07 to 30.06.08, during this time the Russian Welfare Project had approximately 15-20 occasions of service per month including multiple issues, total 138 cases, each case had between five and eight separate issues to deal with.

The Russian Welfare Worker is available at NSS for one day each week.



The position requires the development of information packages for the new arrivals in Australia and their supporters. This information includes: how to access local events, aged services, the NSS's immigration work, health information, as well as services that are available from Centrelink.

Face-to-face counseling, information, advice and referral of service were given to the Russian speakers to help them in dealing with: Centrelink, Hunter Area Health, TAFE, Australian Business Institution, Migration advice and assistance. In working together with these services, the worker was able to provide assistance and support to the clients.

A number of information sessions were organised for the Russian speaking people in the Newcastle area: a Centrelink payments session, educational session with Austraining Business Institute, one session with an Immigrant Agent, a "Health and beauty" session and two sessions with Hunter Area Health about Menopause and Back problems.

An average of 12 people attended each session. The sessions were successful with the recommendation that they be prepared regularly on settlement issues.

A Russian language Newsletter is published on a monthly basis, providing settlement information for new arrivals. The vocation sessions and programs for cultural cooking and craft classes were successfully established. The role of community building was supported through cultural events, celebrations and social gatherings: Picnic, Family's party, Russian New Year party, Russian Christmas party for children, Women's Theatre performance, Children's Picture competition, International Women's day celebration, Social gathering with games, dancing and music, also, Australian Day Celebrations where through participating in the multicultural festival, concert, craft and parade the Russian group has represented the Russian Community of Newcastle and has been awarded with \$100 by the Ethnic Communities Council.

During the year, the following meetings were attended to provide cultural awareness, on request, to mainstream service providers, so that they can enhance their services to Russian speakers:

Centrelink Multicultural forum (2), Mental Illness session Hunter CLSD Partners, Refuge week Celebration, First Aid Course, Fire Training Prevention Course, Citizenship ceremony, Settlement Grants Programme information session /DIAC, Legal Seminar on DV & Victims of Crime Compensation, Advocacy, Complaints Handling and Management Workshop Facilitated by the Ombudsman's office, Violence Against women, Identifying & Responding to Risk of harm, "Advanced workshop for domestic violence counselling", training session "Healthy Living for Families", NSS Planning Day, NSS Staff meetings and NSS Caseworkers meetings (8).

Conclusion

The nominated issues were language problems and translation, transport and referrals, health and family problems.

The number of instances of service shows that the Russian community values the services being offered to them. With all NSS support and services, Russian new arrivals are able to participate in different activities, which assist them in gaining knowledge and skills to settle well into Australian society.



Thai Welfare Project

Nellie Srisurapon

Funded by Department of Community Services

The Thai Community throughout Newcastle and the Hunter region has steadily increased over the reporting period of July 2007 to June 2008. As at June 2008, Northern Settlement Services were in contact with 162 households in the region. The majority of clients seeking assistance from NSS are those on working and spouse visas, therefore these new arrivals have limited English. As of November 2007, NSS also started to offer assistance to the Thai community on the Central Coast. NSS is currently in contact with 36 clients and businesses in this region.

A bilingual welfare worker is available for consultation on Tuesdays at Hamilton and Thursday on the Central Coast. Assistance for clients by telephone is available throughout the week. The welfare worker may also make visits to the client's home, place of work or at a professional office by appointment. NSS provides support and information on a variety of issues through various means. This includes mail outs to the community, group meetings, cultural activities, interviews by appointment, drop in visits and outreach. Isolated members of the community are also put in contact with other members in the community with their consent. Assistance is also provided with interpreting when clients visit an NSS migration agent.

Since December 2007, to the present time, most of the support needed within the community has been connected with domestic violence, with some visa holders on temporary spouse visas. Some of these cases have also involved children. All of these clients now have, or are in the process of acquiring AVO's and are in safe accommodation and awaiting DIAC's decision. The majority of these clients who sought assistance from NSS did so from the recommendation of another member of the community.

Table 1 below shows the instances of support on various issues by the Thai Family Worker at NSS.

ISSUES	FACE TO FACE	TELEPHONE
Immigration	24	79
Employment	3	17
Education	3	18
Housing	7	45
Income – Centrelink	11	22
Mental Health	5	16
Domestic Violence	16	56
Legal	12	37
Police	5	26
Family Problems	7	19
Settlement Information	5	36
Health	15	25
Home Visit/Professional Office	59	-
TOTAL	172	396

GROUP AND OUTREACH ACTIVITIES

Individual Mail out	32
Community Mail out	425
Cultural Event/Group Meeting*	6

**Note: Cultural Events have 80 to 120 people in attendance.
Group meetings have 8 to 20 in attendance*

MEETINGS & WORKSHOPS TO IMPROVE PERFORMANCE

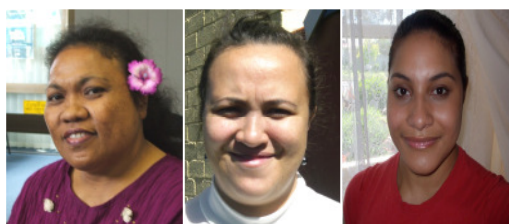
NSS Caseworkers Meetings	6
Interagency Meetings (Central Coast)	2
Workshops/Professional Development	5
Planning Day & other staff training (in house)	2

CHALLENGES ENCOUNTERED OF SERVICE PROVIDER:

- Lack of cultural awareness of some other service providers when dealing with CALD client.
- Lack of awareness for the need of interpreters when dealing with CALD client.
- Lack of information available to client from main service provider when accessed by client. This also includes lack of, or nil, information of main service providers and their numbers, as well as emergency numbers, to CALD clients on arrival to Australia.
- Lack of safe housing for clients experiencing DV.
- Informing clients of Australian Law and their rights; what DV is and how it affects the victim.

Through the majority of this past year, most assistance has been DV related.

- 11 cases have been spouse abuse and 1 case student home stay.
- 5 children ranging in the age from 5 months to 17 years have been involved.
- Of these 12 DV cases, 3 have chosen to stay with their partner, and 3 have returned to their partner.
- The remaining 6 have sought legal proceedings and have moved to safer accommodation and are getting on with a safer and more secure life in Australia.
- NSS continues to have contact with these clients.



Pacific Islander Welfare Project
Juanita Loli, Sara Stankovic & Lydia Manusiu
 Funded by Department of Community Services

The Pacific Islanders Welfare Project has been in operation since 1990 under the umbrella of the Migrant Resource Centre, was managed by its own Management Committee (PIWC) and funded by the Department of Community Services (DOCS). The Northern Settlement Services took over the management of this project from April 2007 employing two workers who aim to achieve the following objectives.

1. Supporting children, young people, individual and families of Pacific Islanders to enable the enhancement of their independence, safety, self-esteem and or quality of life within the communities by:
 - i) providing information, advice, referrals and advocacy to individuals and families.
 - ii) providing group work to the Pacific Island Women's Groups attended by 25 – 35 women.
 - iii) providing tax assistance through Tax Help Volunteer Programs (ATO)
 - iv) providing ongoing support, advocacy and casework services to client group through case-plan.

2. Building strong communities and social capital / undertaking community development so that Pacific Island Communities are well informed, resourced, and connected and that equity and diversity are embraced by:
 - i) providing information via the newsletters distributed monthly to the Samoans and bi-monthly to the Tongans. This information includes family activities in the areas the Pacific Islanders live and information regarding changes to government policies etc... The purpose being to inform Pacific Islanders to enhance awareness of relevant services they can access. Information is also transmitted on a weekly basis to the Samoan and Tongan Communities via the Community Radio programs on Radio 2NURFM 103.7 (Sunday nights for the Samoans & Friday nights for the Tongans) and is heard by an audience of 300 – 400
 - ii) Workers maintain networking with government and non-government agencies and service providers by attending meetings throughout the year for awareness and development. Agencies and service providers include: Centrelink, Department of Housing, DOCS, Ethnic Communities Council, Hunter Tenants' Advice / Advocacy Service, Legal Aid, Migrant Health Services, etc...attending meetings ie Northern Settlement Services Caseworkers' Meetings, NSS Staff , Centrelink Multicultural Forum, CALD DOCS Advisory Group etc..

Tax Returns and Emergency Relief (welfare assistance in paying bills ie Electricity, Gas, Telephone and Water) for clients who visit the centre, are available to all low income earners and Centrelink recipients of Pacific Island, CALD or Anglo Saxon background. They are either self referred or referred by other service providers / or centre based referrals. Support is also given via home / hospital visits and referral to other services with provision of ongoing case management.

This statistical data represents a 12 months period (November 2007 – November 2008)

ISSUES PRESENTED & NUMBER OF CLIENTS

SERVICE OR ASSISTANCE PROVIDED	NUMBER OF CLIENTS
Accommodation & Housing Issues	50
Domestic Violence	6
Employment Issues	42
Health Issues	55
Immigration (Citizenship / Sponsorship)	200
Legal Issues	24
Youth Issues	80
Tax Returns (Tax Help Program)	255
EAPA (Welfare / Emergency Relief)	508
Education & Training	47
Family Issues	25
General Information / Support	146
Other	128

It has been a very productive year for us particularly with new Pacific Island families moving into the area and others leaving for interstate. For a couple of months, Sara Stankovic took maternal leave and Lydia Manusiu was recruited for the Tongan worker's role as well as two weeks of Samoan when I took compassionate leave.

We very much appreciate the support of the Director and Administration Staff and also our Team Leader. We enjoy working with such wonderful staff. To our Director, thank you so very much for being the best, for being sensitive to our needs and for being there for us when we need your advice and encouragement. We would not have been able to achieve our objectives and take on the workload without your help. May God give you added strength to continue the good work you do. Thank you from the bottom of our hearts.

We wish you all a safe and happy Christmas with a prosperous New Year.



Migrant & Refugee Women's Support Project (SGP)

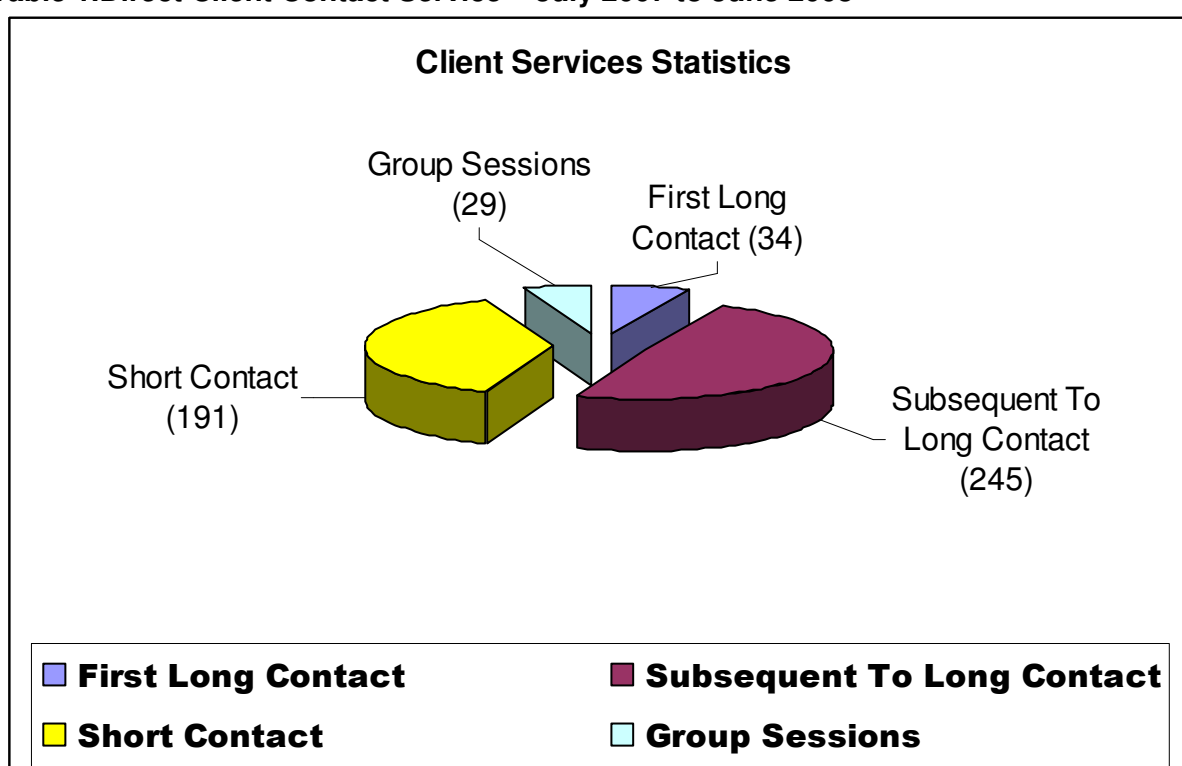
Zenaida Edmunds

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This project provides support services to migrant and refugee women, who are experiencing physical and psychological crisis and hardships through isolation, effects of torture and trauma, domestic violence, homelessness and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

The service includes; individual support, referrals, information and group activities.

Table 1. Direct Client Contact Service – July 2007 to June 2008



Casework consists mainly of domestic violence (DV) and related issues, such as police, legal matters, family law, accommodation, health, counselling, financial and migration issues.

Other Settlement issues include;

Employment, Education/training, learning English, family relationships, childcare, life skills, social isolation, financial, driving and overseas qualification.

Group Work

The Multicultural Women's Group usually meet once a month with attendances averaging 7 – 11 women from various cultural backgrounds.

The Burundi Women's Group regularly meet once a week for the sewing class, attendances averaging 9 – 12 women. Information sessions and other activities are held once a month with attendances averaging 9 – 12 women.

Multicultural Women's Group:**Activities include;**

- Coffee and Conversation
- Cooking Demonstration – Singapore Noodles
- Jewellery Making
- Easy Digital Collage
- Making Flyers Using Easy Software
- Cooking Demonstration – Sudanese Cuisine
- Culture Sharing – Parenting practices

Information Services:

- Housing/Tenancy
- Early Childhood Intervention Program
- Multicultural Services Expo
- Office of Fair Trading

Burundi Women's Group:**Activities include;**

- Sewing Classes
- Healthy Cooking – Stir-fry Vegetables
- Cooking Demonstration – Breads and Scones
- Cake and Conversation Morning
- House Cleaning – Kitchen
- Burundi Women's Choir – performed at Multicultural Variety Concert and Hunter Multicultural Christmas Carols
- Mother's Day Lunch
- Picnic at Hunter Valley Vineyard

Information Services:

- Multicultural Services Expo
- Early Childhood Intervention Program
- Health Session – Vaccination / Immunisation
- Personal Care and Hygiene
- Parenting Practices
- Domestic Violence (DV)

House cleaning workshops are still continuing to include bathroom/toilet, carpet/floors, walls, windows and ceiling.

Settlement Needs Issues Identified:

- Lack of accommodation in Women's Refuge places for women experiencing domestic violence.
- Lack of opportunities for migrant and refugee women to participate in the workforce.
- Lack of English literacy is a great barrier for migrants and refugees to participate in mainstream Australian society.
- Generally adjusting to Australian way of life, in terms of gender roles and responsibilities, family relationships, family finances, health, food and parenting practices.

I would like to thank my colleagues especially my team leader, Pet Kelly for ongoing support and encouragement, Alex Burns for work program guidance and direction and Amany George, MNC Manager for ongoing technical support.



Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)

Miza Torlakovic

Funded by the Department of Community Services

Project Description: NSW Department of Community Services funds multicultural Family Project under the NSW-*Families First* program. This project provides support to new parents and families with children aged 0-8, from culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) backgrounds. The target group comprises first time parents, teenage parents and to parents with a developmental disability; and/or other special needs, living in the Newcastle and Lake Macquarie LGAs.

During the last 12 months a total of 69 families coming from 25 different ethnic backgrounds accessed the service, with an average of 9 new families presenting for assistance in this period. The referrals to this project mainly come from the following agencies: Hunter New England Area Health, Women's refuges, Child Care Services and the Mental Health Services. NSS staff in other projects also refer to this project.

An increase of self-referral has occurred with approximately 18 clients contacting the project, as they have required further support.

Table 1 indicates the issues were presented to the service for assistance and/or referral

Table 1: Number of Clients Contact Instances and specific Issues

Problems/issues	Face to Face	Phone	Problems/Issues	Face to Face	Phone
Family Problems	149	95	Legal matters	163	139
Domestic Violence	90	122	Police	14	27
Child Care / Children's issues	182	110	Torture & Trauma	38	75
Health issues	186	93	Mental Health		
Income support/finances	149	206	Youth Issues	33	53
Settlement Information	119	60	Immigration and Citizenship	56	75
Learning English	63	74	Accommodation and housing	148	117
Employment	98	32	Education/training	149	76
			Other*	364	172

***Other** 364 occasions of service includes: Isolation, home/hospitals visits, case conferences, assisting with documents, transport and filling forms.

A major focus of the service was on new mothers, with very high rates of support required in the ante- and postnatal periods.

All 69 families received home visitation (total of 157 visitations in the course of the year) averaging at least three weekly visits. Joint home visits with other service providers were used as a good opportunity to observe parent/child interactions, engagement and behavior patterns and to provide informal education accordingly. Most home visits took place after hours including weekends. These were generally supervised home visitations and some at times of crises when there was concerns for children's safety where DOCS had to be notified.

The Families First project strongly networks with a wide range of mainstream and community agencies to deliver the service and these include: the Hunter New England Multicultural Service, the John Hunter Hospital, Community Mental Health Services in Newcastle and Lake Macquarie, the Department of Housing, Compass Housing, all women's Refuges, Women's Housing, the Family In Sight project, Newcastle Home Start- Family Action Centre, DASH, Newcastle Family Support, Hunter Community Legal Centre, Hunter Women's Domestic Violence Court Advocacy Service, Early Childhood Intervention Program -Special Education Centre(University of Newcastle), TAFE and various Child Care/ Play Schools, Churches and other Charity organizations.

The project is also very closely networked with other NSS services which offer specialist additional services, such as migration advice and assistance and assistance with financial support (EAPA and Water Board Vouchers).

Several families have been linked to parenting programs conducted by Relationship Australia. The project facilitated the attendance of supported families to 2 Workshops in Specific Languages: one for Burundi Clients (6 women and 4 Men attended the workshop as it was a Swahili speaking session) and one for 10 Sudanese women (presented in Arabic). These workshops were based on the "Strengths to Strengths" objectives, a family relationship program for Humanitarian Entrant families. This provide a very positive outcome for the families attending and will now lead to more in depth courses for mothers with dependent children in partnership with the Newcastle Family Support Service and the Family Relationship Skills Program.

Project Highlights

The project has been very effective in building excellent partnerships with a full range of service providers as mentioned above. Further, the project has provided support in assisting in improving the lives of families with young children, especially in crisis situations. Support for the project from Charlestown Uniting Church and the Samaritans Foundation where Christmas Hampers and toys were given to the families of the project before Christmas at the time most needed.

Training and Skill Building

The project has had good training opportunities which have included: a 2 day program on Identifying and Responding to the Risk of Harm, a 2 day "Case Management" skill building session from a Strengths Perspective, an Advanced Workshop for Domestic Violence counselling on Changes to Family Law, Good for Kids-Healthy living for Families and Supported Accommodation and Housing -living with Mental Illness.

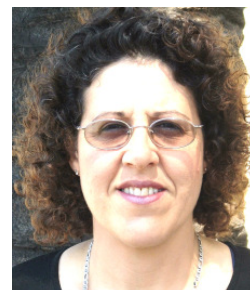
NSS ADMINISTRATION & ADDITIONAL STAFF



Ms Arlene Richards
Financial Controller



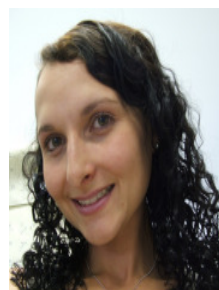
Ms Marianne Mohr
Assistant Financial Controller



Ms Helen Buchanan
Specialist Caseworker
OH&S Consultant



Ms Sinead Buckley
Office Manager
(Resigned April 2008)



Mary Milevski
Office Manager



Silvia Ruano
Senior Administration Officer



Ms Helen Short
Administration Officer

CENTRE USAGE

2007-2008



African Community Council	Latvian Group
Ba'hai Community of Newcastle	Lettessi
Bosnian Community of Newcastle	Migrant Health Unit
Burundi Dance Group	Multicultural Dementia Carers Group
Burundi Women's Choir	Newcastle & Hunter Ethnic Choral Society
Burundi Community of Newcastle	Newcastle Theatre Company
Burundi & Congolese Community	Newcastle Multicultural Interagency
Centrelink Multicultural Forum	Newcastle Akebono Japanese Group
Community Refugee Support	New Arrival Welcomes
DIAC Immigration Officers Outreach	Pacific RAC
Estonian Community of Newcastle	PCG Church
Filipino Community Choir	Russian Women's Group
Filipino Women's Group	Russian School
First Aid Group	Refugee Council
French Group	Samoan Women's Group
Greek Macedonian Brotherhood Pavlos Melas	Slovenian Association of Newcastle "Tivoli"
Hamilton Multicultural Walkers	Spanish Group
Hamilton Olympic Soccer Club	STARTTS Counselling
Hunter Refugee Network	Sudanese Community of Newcastle
Hunter Community Legal Clinic	Tamil Language School
Migrant Interagency	Tongan Choir
International Singers	United Nations Association Australia

2008 at Northern Settlement Services Limited



**The Hon Minister Linda Burney MP visits NSS,
with Minister for the Hunter Jodi McKay MP
& NSS Management & Staff**





Our "Pampering Day" for HMRS carers



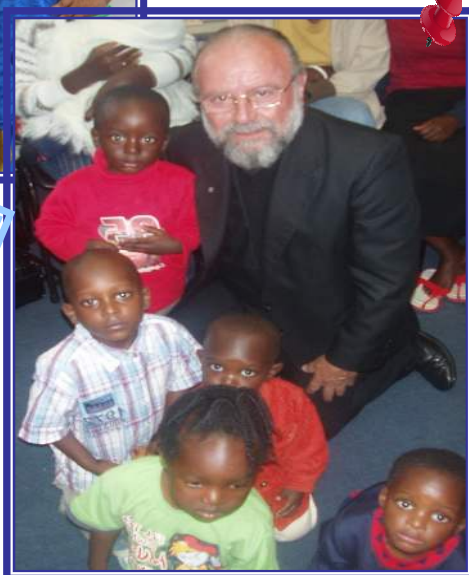
Members of the Filipino Choir of Newcastle



**Left:
Samoan Women's
Group**



Singleton Women's' Multicultural Group



**NSS Board Member Father Zervas
meets with African children**

NSS STAFF PLANNING DAY - 2008

NSS Staff participating in a cooking class as a team building activity...



*NSS Management & Staff
remember our beautiful friend & colleague*

ANKIE - ANNE JOHANNA DUPREE
1938 - 2008



*For the dedication to her work & her volunteers
& for the special person she was to all of us.*





FINANCIAL REPORT

as provided by

Cutcher & Neale

For the year ending 30 June 2008